# The Law of Graphic Equalisation — Theory

Minimal Recursive Dynamics, Collapse, Frame-Relative Identity, and Residual

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**Abstract**

This paper proposes that one minimal structure underlies phenomena usually studied apart — physical, cognitive, and institutional — and that the case for it rests not on a new result in any single field but on the recurrence of the same structure across fields that developed it independently, without reference to one another or to this account. The structure is information-level: represented state, the transformations admissible upon it, and the realisation of a single continuation from what was possible. Almost none of its components is individually novel, and that is the point: the claim is the *arrangement* — that known pieces compose into one substrate, and that the composition is what recurs. It carries its own falsifier, and fails if the recurrence is an artefact of a sufficiently general description rather than a property of the domains themselves.

Read at this level, several things ordinarily treated as background turn out to be constructed rather than given — a privileged standpoint from which to measure, and time itself, among them — and the substrate that remains once every removable commitment is stripped away is strikingly small, with most of what is called law being contingent upon it rather than necessary to it.

These are claims about information, of which physical theory is taken to be one embodiment rather than a rival. The theory asserts nothing about the nature of pre-relational existence; it begins where distinguishable relational structure can first be represented, and treats the limit of that reach as a frontier instrumentation moves rather than a fixed wall.

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# Part I
# Foundations

## 1 Scope and epistemic status

This paper contains the smallest set of commitments required for the later theory. It distinguishes axioms and definitions, deductive consequences, groundings into existing theories, and empirical hypotheses. It deliberately excludes executor design, rule scheduling, proposal records, retry protocols, valuation algorithms, and controller architecture.

**The companions, and the short names used here.** Twelve documents make up this programme. This paper is one of them and refers to the other eleven; the short name in the middle column is the only form used below. One of the twelve — the construction paper — is a realisation rather than a result. It is numbered A1 rather than in the series, and is not circulated with it. Where it is cited below it is cited as evidence that something was built and behaved as described, which is a claim a reader may decline to credit; nothing here depends on how it was built, and this programme is not an instruction for building one.

| Title | Short name | Scope |
|---|---|---|
| *Is* | *Is* | The base claim: to be is to stand in relation and to cohere in it. No time, cause or rule. |
| *The Law of Graphic Equalisation — Theory* | this paper | The substrate $G = (g, r, \Gamma)$, collapse, residual, frames, economics. |
| *. . . Statement* | the statement | This paper's claims without their arguments, generated from it. |
| *. . . Physics Grounding* | the physics companion | $c$, relativity, the Born rule, the constants, the second law. |
| *. . . Mind and Self Grounding* | the mind companion | Free will, self-models, personal identity, death. |
| *Seldon Manifolds — Theory* | *Seldon* | The geometry of reachable futures. |
| *Seldon Manifolds — Psychological Grounding* | the Seldon grounding | Forward models and the aperture of one embodiment. |
| *The Law of Narrative Momentum* | the momentum paper | First-class history, cost-conditioned persistence, revision. |
| *Narrativium — Theory* | *Narrativium* | Frame-relative capacity for consequential deformation. |
| *A Constructive Realisation. . .* (A1) | the construction paper | A realisation of the substrate. Numbered apart from the series because it is not circulated with it; cited where it is the evidence for a claim, and its contents are not set out here. |
| *Frames, Relation, and the Empty Limit* | the frames companion | Whether a well-formed frame approaches a view from nowhere. |
| *Assessing an Account of This Kind* | the assessment companion | What a universal framework can risk and what it earns instead. |

*Why these are twelve documents and not one.* The division is a claim and not an editorial convenience, which matters now that this document is long enough for merging them to look like tidying. The companion offers itself *as evidence that transformation and grammar are separable rather than constitutive*, and that evidence exists only because the two sit in different documents; the same holds one level up for every boundary here. The ledger of Remark 2.6 is *what this*

*paper postulates over* the companion, and it is checkable because there is a companion to check it against — merge them and it becomes an argument about earlier chapters, which is not an accounting. Axiom −1 is a guard here and a commitment in the groundings, and that split needs the groundings to exist. And the documents fail differently on purpose: a physics grounding can be wrong without the substrate being wrong, which is the [SHAPE]/[DETAIL] distinction at the scale of a document rather than of a claim. One text would put every commitment inside one blast radius.

What the division does require is that material sits in the document whose question it answers, and that is a live failure mode rather than a settled one: a quarter of this paper's opening section was assessment material until it was moved to the companion written for it. The remedy there was to *restore* a boundary, not to dissolve one. The closest case in the other direction is the frames companion, four pages answering one bounded question and carrying no independent risk; it stays separate because the question is separate, and that is the weakest instance of this argument rather than a representative one.

**Level of the claims.** The claims here are about *information*: distinction, relation, frame, admissibility, realisation, residual. Physical theory is taken to be an embodiment of information rather than a competitor to it, alongside other embodiments — cognitive, institutional, computational — which differ in how much structure they instantiate rather than in kind. This is the position that licenses treating an inertial reference frame and a representational frame as the same sort of object (Axiom −1), and it locates the epistemic boundary below both: what embodiments are made of remains unspecified. It also fixes what this account does not attempt, which is worth saying once rather than conceding repeatedly: the constants belong to the embodiments. Where a number appears anywhere in this programme it is borrowed from a grounding and never derived here, because a framework that produced the constants would be a rival physical theory rather than the thing physical theories are stated in. *This is the framework the rules live in, not a re-derivation of the rules.*

The layering must not be allowed to function as a shield, so the condition under which a physical result bears on a claim here is stated in advance. **A physical result bears on an information-level claim when it settles an informational fact**, and not when it merely disagrees about mechanism in one embodiment. Bell's theorem and Kochen–Specker are the model: they do not report a mechanism, they establish that a class of pre-measurement values cannot be re-read as unheld-but-realised, which is a fact about distinction and therefore reaches this level directly (Section 17). Landauer's principle is a second instance, establishing a lower bound on the physical cost of a specified informational operation (Landauer, 1961); under the substrate's no-copy default it is read below as the floor cost of change as such rather than of erasure specifically (Section 7). A result that constrains what can be distinguished, held, or converted is admissible evidence here; a result about how a particular embodiment happens to be arranged is not.

**Provenance of the primitives.** The components of $G = (g, r, \Gamma)$ and its dynamic were not derived together from a single starting point, and stating how each arrived is more useful than presenting the triple as an austere posit reasoned out in advance.

- $g$, the typed graph, arrived by *observation*: several unrelated engineering problems turned out to have one shape — labelled things joined by labelled relations. Both labellings there are those frames' own, and so is the sorting into kinds — though not as decoration, since kinds arise in any graph that runs and those frames all ran. What is not supplied at all is that the relations differ (Remark 3.11).

- $\Gamma$, admissibility, arrived by *insight*, and preceded the collapse operator. Its original working image was a sieve: the graph is pressed through admissibility, and what may pass is what $\Gamma$

admits.

- $\mathcal{C}$, collapse, arrived by *constraint*. Any theory of this kind must be compatible with quantum measurement, which is the regime where the distinction between indexed possibility and realised history is experimentally irreducible. The operator was adopted from there and generalised (Section 17).
- $r$, the operative transformation structure, arrived by *implementation*: a construction that runs requires something that performs the transformations, and the requirement appeared when the theory was first built rather than when it was first stated.

The last of these has a consequence for how the companion construction paper should be read: construction has been a *source* of this theory rather than only a test of it. The evidence is $r$'s own provenance immediately above — a primitive of the substrate that arrived because something had to perform the transformations in a system that ran — and the construction paper's closing list of eleven distinctions that implementation forced upon the theory records eleven further instances of the same direction of travel, about antecedence, identity typing, residual and absent dimensions.

**What the claim is, and how to read for it.** Almost none of the individual components below is novel, and the prior-art sections say so specifically rather than as a courtesy: typed graphs, admissibility grammars, fixed-point closure, frame-relative measurement, description-length criteria and actualisation operators all have established literatures. A reader who evaluates each component against its own field will therefore find each one known or borrowed, and will be locally correct on every count. Evaluating the parts individually cannot reach the composition claim in either direction — neither to support it nor to refute it — because the parts are stipulated to be known.

Accordingly the composition carries its own falsifiability commitment, stated in Section 19 alongside the component ones. It fails if the recurrence across domains is an artefact of description — that is, if the structure is recoverable in unrelated domains only because a sufficiently general vocabulary can be applied to anything, and not because those domains share it. The evidence bearing on it is independent re-derivation: cases in which a domain arrived at the structure without reference to this theory, in its own idiom, while solving its own problem — which bears on the artefact reading without settling the composition claim, at the strength Section 19 gives.

**Epistemic boundary.** This theory does not attempt to specify the intrinsic nature of pre-relational existence. It begins at the first level at which distinguishable relational structure is scientifically representable. What it assumes at that point is stated separately in the companion *Is*: that to be is to stand in relation, and that nothing further — no sequence, no cause, no rule — is required for there to be anything at all. That companion carries one claim and this paper begins after it. The move it makes is

$$\boxed{? \dashrightarrow \text{observable relational structure} \implies \text{graph representation},}$$

and the dashed arrow marks what is *not* claimed. The pre-graph substrate may be continuous, discrete, purely mathematical, or unclassifiable from any frame available here; the theory asserts nothing about it. What is asserted begins at the second arrow: *where* distinguishable relational structure is representable, it admits graph representation and the dynamics below govern it.

This boundary is stated because a stronger reading is available and is not the position of this paper. The theory is not the claim that reality is fundamentally graph-shaped.

Two clarifications, because the boundary is routinely read as weaker and as more permanent than it is.

*Within* distinguishability the claim is not hedged. Where every measurement that can be made of something, and every operation that can be performed on it, is captured by treating it as a typed graph, then no difference remains for the question "but is it really" to name, and a question naming no difference has no content under Axiom −1. Functional identity is not a weaker sense of identity here; it is the whole of what identity could mean without a view from nowhere.

And the boundary is a *frontier*, not a wall. It is fixed in *definition* — it sits at distinguishability, wherever that currently lies — and moving in *extent*, since its contents are contingent and diminish as instrumentation is built. Anything that becomes measurable passes from beyond it to within it. This is the extensive unboundedness of the substrate applied to the theory's own scope: always one further step available, no expectation of exhausting it, and no warrant for treating the current contents of the far side as permanent.

## What kind of thing this is claimed to be

What kind of contribution that makes, how the claim behaves as details change, and how the account scores against the demand a substrate claim invites, are assessment questions and are treated in the assessment companion rather than here.

**What kind of document this is.** *It is not a paper, and the paper exists separately.* Twenty sections in seven parts carry a hundred numbered results — nineteen definitions, twenty-seven propositions, forty remarks, six corollaries, four hypotheses, two theorems, two axioms — over eighty-three references. That is the shape of a reference work, and it is why this one opens with a table of contents and a map of its companions. The document a reader wanting the claims rather than their derivations should have is the *statement*, which is generated from this one, says the same things in twenty pages, and argues for none of them. Nothing below is written on the assumption of a linear reading.

A reader arriving at the length should know what sets it. A normal paper reports a result *inside* an established framework, and is short because it inherits one — the vocabulary, the methods, the standards of evidence all arrive for free, and the contribution is the delta. This document establishes a framework instead, so it inherits none of that and must install it: frame, aperture, admissibility, residual, primitives, and the economics over them all have to be defined before any claim can be stated in them. Its principal move is also *removal* — showing how little is required — and each removal is a separate argument that cannot be compressed into the others.

That is this account's own economics applied to its own reception, and it is not a plea. A reader is a frame; a paper of this kind is a capability change; and the aperture has to move before anything can be said through it. The installation is paid in pages, and papers that found a vocabulary have historically been long for that reason while papers written in one are short.

The argument is only available because the alternative was checked. "It is a different kind of thing" is what the author of any overlong document says, and the discriminator is whether the length is installation or *accumulation*. It has now been measured for the second twice, the second time by a reader trying to cut it: five passes over presentation removed about eleven hundred words of announcements, self-description, duplicated enumerations and narrated revision, and *found no argument that could be removed without losing an argument* — two attempts on content were withdrawn on measurement, and the recommendation that a section's content was one sentence turned out to be false of the section. That is a compression frontier reached rather than a claim of parsimony. The first measurement was blunter and came to the same thing: a quarter of it turned out to be argument about how to assess it rather than statement of it, and that is now a separate companion. What remains is installation, and the shorter statement companion exists for readers who want the account without it.

## 2 Axiom −1: relativity of grounding

**Axiom -1** (Relativity of grounding)**.** *There is no operational view from nowhere. Every distinction, measurement, identity relation, admissibility judgement, and represented quantity is made in some frame. Frames may represent one another, but no quantity used by the theory requires a frame-independent evaluator.*

*Remark* 2.1 (The axiom in bits)*.* The axiom is clearer stated as a measure, and stated that way it is the same result as Remark 3.9 at the other end of the same scale.

A view is informative in proportion to the relation between viewer and viewed: what the one tells you about the other is what a view delivers, and it is measured in bits. A view from nowhere is a standpoint standing in no relation to what it views. So it does not deliver a partial view, or a distorted one, or one this account happens to have no access to. *It delivers no bits.*

That inverts the picture the phrase invites. A view from nowhere is ordinarily imagined as the best view — unobstructed, unbiased, complete — and the axiom is heard as denying us something desirable. The measure says the opposite: seeing is standing in relation, so a standpoint that adds nothing to what it views also *receives* nothing from it. The view from nowhere is not the complete view but the empty one, and what the axiom denies is not a vantage we are missing but one that would tell us nothing if we had it.

The same fact turns up at both ends of one scale. A self-relation has both ends the same and carries no bits (Remark 3.9); a view from nowhere has no relation at all and carries no bits. Zero distance and infinite distance are the two ways of getting nothing, and in between — standing apart from something, at some remove, from somewhere — is where information is. It is also why the companion's graph follows: a richer intrinsic form would have to be read off from nowhere, which is to say read off at zero bits, which is not reading it off.

*And on this reading it is not an axiom.* It follows. To be is to stand in relation; a relation is what carries information, being what tells you about one end given the other; so a standpoint standing in no relation to what it views carries nothing about it, and there is no informative view from nowhere. Nothing is posited there that the companion's claim and the measure do not already give. The axiom's own wording anticipates this and should be read as meaning it: what it denies is an *operational* view from nowhere — a view that does something — and the qualifier was never decoration.

Two other readings of its status do not survive. It is not a posit among posits, and it is not a costless methodological guard, since the groundings use it to license positive results and carry it as a commitment that can fail. A consequence has content and can fail, which is what the guard reading could not accommodate. This one fails if a view can be informative without standing in relation to what it views, or if relation is not what carries information here — both checkable, and the second is the companion's own identification of distinction with relation, so the exposure is real and is where a reader should press.

It keeps its number and its prohibition-form for the reason the next remark gives: what it denies is imported freely, so a consequence that nobody would otherwise derive has to be stated before the counting starts. *Not an axiom, and stated first anyway* is what the numbering records.

*Remark* 2.2 (Two familiar statements of the same zero, and the misreading both invite)*.* Two things people already say turn out to be this measure, and both are usually said in a form the measure corrects.

*Everything is nothing.* Taken as a claim about what there is, it is false and obviously so. Taken as the measure says it, it is exact: a view of everything from outside everything stands in no relation to what it views — there is nothing left over to stand in one — so it delivers zero, which is what a view of nothing delivers. *The totality and the empty set meet at zero bits*, which is also where this programme's own empty limit sits. The equality is between two *views*, not between two *things*, and the usual version slides from the first to the second: from *no standpoint*

*distinguishes them* to *they are the same.* That slide asserts an identity from a standpoint the same measure says would be empty, so it refutes itself in the act, and Axiom −1 is what blocks it. From somewhere — which is the only place anything is — everything is emphatically not nothing.

*The pale blue dot* (Sagan, 1994) is the same scale approached rather than reached. Distance costs bits: at enough remove, everything anyone has cared about is one pixel, and the force of the image is that information collapse felt rather than computed. The nihilist reading takes the limit to have been reached and concludes that nothing matters. Sagan's own text does not, and the measure says why it need not: *that's here, that's home, that's us* is a reading from a frame, and a frame at zero remove from what it cares about is where the bits are. Scale indexes mattering; it does not abolish it.

The two share one correction, which is the whole of what this account adds to either. *The zero is a property of the view and not of the viewed.* A thing does not become nothing by being seen from far enough away, and everything does not become nothing by being taken all at once. What goes to zero is what a standpoint at no relation, or at unbounded remove, receives — and there is no such standpoint occupied by anyone, which is why neither statement licenses the conclusion usually drawn from it.

*Remark* 2.3 (The method is one of the account's own consequences)*.* Minimum description length appears twice in this programme under one name, and the second appearance is not a method. In the companion it is the method — *prefer the shortest account that suffices* — and is imported rather than invented. It is also *derivable*: relation is what carries the information, a relation with no content of its own adds nothing to what a thing is, so what a thing is is its shortest sufficient relational description. That is the same principle applied to *things* rather than to accounts, and it is what the claim that information is everything cashes to. Neither grip is prior; they are one principle held at two places.

Naming the norm's source makes the size of the second grip visible, and it is larger than it looks. The companion identifies minimum description length as Occam's razor with the vagueness removed — a norm on *accounts*, telling you which of two descriptions to prefer. The constitutive reading is that same razor turned on *things*: not that a shorter description is the better model of a thing, but that the shortest sufficient one is what the thing comes to. That is a considerably stronger claim than the methodological razor anyone would grant, and it is stated here as a separate one rather than carried in on the back of it.

One extension is required and is named rather than hidden. Remark 3.9 settles the case of a relation carrying no information *at all*; this uses the conditional form — no information *given the rest.* A duplicated edge is not zero-bit on its own, only conditional on the edge it duplicates. The step from the unconditional result to the conditional one is plausible and is not proved here.

Well-posedness comes from Axiom −1 and could come from nowhere else, since description length is defined only against a vocabulary and *shortest simpliciter* is not a quantity. The standing objection to any constitutive reading of description length — that complexity is machine-relative up to an additive constant — is therefore not answered here but *accepted*: the constant is the frame. Converting an objection into a thesis is only honest where the thesis was motivated independently of the objection, which is the case here, Axiom −1 having been argued for on other grounds entirely.

One consequence is easy to miss. *If the method is a consequence of the account, the method cannot be independent support for the account.* There is nothing vicious in the circle — a description of everything describes its own production — but the most that may be claimed from it is consistency: were the method and the ontological reading to disagree, the account would be self-undermining, and they do not disagree. That is a check passed and not evidence gathered, and it is the weaker of the two things a reader might have taken the agreement to show.

*The method was never evidence*, and calling its loss a cost gets the sign wrong. It is a

selection principle: it did its work in choosing what to keep, never in showing that what was kept is so. Finding it to be a consequence removes it from a column it had no business in, and by Definition 7.7 that is not a loss but the thing that definition names — paying for nothing that does no work. What the correction does not license is the stronger reading, that needing no support is better without limit. The account's live commitments are answerable and are untouched by this. And a description that genuinely needed no support would be the object the companion on frames arrives at from the other direction: nothing held, no work done, hence nothing to support and nothing to be supported. *Perfection and well-formedness part company there*, because the criterion is work done *for* something and at zero work it has no argument to take — the same collapse as the self-relation and the view from nowhere, reached a third way. Needing less support is a direction. Needing none is not the end of that direction but the point at which the measure stops applying.

*Remark* 2.4 (Why it is numbered before the axioms). The number is not decoration and it is not a claim that this is a different kind of thing — an earlier reading here held it was a methodological guard rather than a commitment, and that reading does not survive the groundings, which use it to license positive results and carry it as a commitment that can fail. The number records something else: *what it denies is imported for free.* A reader does not arrive neutral on whether there is a view from nowhere; they arrive already using one, without having decided to, because reading a claim as being about how things are rather than about how things are from somewhere is the default and costs nothing to adopt. An axiom that cancels a default has to be stated before the counting starts, since by the time the first axiom is numbered the import has already happened.

That is also why it is the one thing forbidden rather than one more thing asserted. Everything else this account does at the base is removal — take a candidate away and see whether the account still stands. This cannot be done by removal, because what it removes is not in the text to be taken out; it is in the reader, and it returns unless it is refused explicitly. A prohibition is the only form that does that job.

*Remark* 2.5. This removes a privileged frame, not determinacy. Within a frame, relations may be exact, restrictive, comparable, and falsifiable. The standpoint is structurally consonant with relational formulations in physics, especially relational quantum mechanics, in which physical facts are indexed to interactions rather than assigned from a privileged observer-independent state description (Rovelli, 1996). The present axiom is broader and is not derived from that programme.

*Remark* 2.6 (What this paper postulates over *Is*). The ledger is the table. The prose after it is why each entry sits where it does, and a reader who wants only the account can stop at the table and the paragraph on how to read the count. The entries are named rather than counted, because a count can be carried unchanged while the list beneath it grows and a list cannot. Where an entry was arrived at by withdrawing something the withdrawal is stated with it, since a ledger whose entries cannot be checked against what they replaced is not checkable; the fuller history is in the review record.

| Status | Entry | Where argued, and what it replaced |
|---|---|---|
| Inherited | Both of the companion's propositions: to be is to stand in relation, and to cohere in it | *Is*, Propositions 1.1–1.2. Taking the second adds nothing, the companion deriving it from the first plus the measure (Remark 3.10) |
| Admitted | That anything *happens* | Unpaid, and one of two — the other being the companion's claim that there is anything at all |
| Taken to follow | The transformations $r$, and $\Gamma$ with them | Something has to do the happening; the least graph that does anything is a rule. Two candidates remain open |
| Postulated | A realisation operator; a destroy/preserve distinction | Both folded away at some point and restored by audit; the attempt to dissolve collapse traded it for union |
| Not postulated, a consequence | Axiom $-1$ | Follows from the companion's claim plus the measure (Remark 2.1); guard in this paper, commitment in the groundings |

*Inherited.* The companion's claim, that to be is to stand in relation *and to cohere in it.* Both halves are inherited and the second is not decorative: relation alone is satisfied by a relation to oneself, which carries nothing, so what is taken over is the companion's pair of propositions and not the first alone (Remark 3.10). Nothing is added here by taking the second, since the companion derives it from the first together with the measure.

*Admitted.* That anything *happens.* The companion is careful to say this is not required for there to be anything, so it is a real addition, and it is not derived from anything here. It is one of two unpaid entries, the other being the companion's claim that there is anything at all; neither is grounded here, and an earlier version of this remark counted only one.

*Taken to follow from the admission, with two candidates open.* The transformations $r$. Something has to do the happening, whatever does it is a graph, and the least graph that can do anything is a pattern together with a change it makes — so a rule is a graph that does something. Admissibility comes with it rather than beside it: $\Gamma$ names the rules that decide admit-or-residual, and Definition 3.17's writing of $\mathcal{P}$ in terms of $\Gamma$ is a definitional dependence and not an ontological one.

One thing the corpus states in several places without naming its origin belongs here, and an earlier version of this remark named the wrong origin. *Existence is not contents.* A thing holding nothing is still a thing provided it stands in a relation, so emptiness is not non-existence, and a dimension holding no value is not a dimension that is not there.

That is derived, and it is derived from the companion's claim rather than from admissibility. Definition 12.1 already gives it in this paper: NULL is the edge's non-existence, where a value is an edge that exists and carries one, so revoking a dimension is the container ceasing to instantiate the relation. The Seldon companion's own definition of a dimension says the same — a dimension exists in a frame only where the frame instantiates the relation needed to distinguish values along it, and if that relation is absent the dimension is undefined rather than present at zero. Both are relational and neither mentions a grammar.

The earlier version argued instead that an empty set is a set while having no members, so what makes a thing is that it is *admitted* as one, and concluded that admissibility is forced. It fails three ways. The premise contradicts the companion, which holds the empty set to be the one perfect thing and perfection to be unavailable to an existent — so on that account the empty set does not stand in a relation and no question about its existence arises. The word *admitted* then slides: read as *stands in the relation that individuates it* the argument is the companion's claim restated, and read as *a grammar licenses it* it is denied by Remark 3.2, which says relations survive stripping $\Gamma$. And the conclusion would make existence a matter of what

some frame's grammar admits, which by Axiom -1 indexes existence to frames — reinstalling exactly the reading the companion disowns when it says a tree falling unobserved is as related to its forest as one that is watched. The candidate list this minimality claim was tested against is: a brute unconditioned change, a change with no pattern, an external agency, a primitive not decomposable into match-and-change, and a continuous flow admitting no step. The first two are rules with an empty match; the third is excluded by the companion's claim rather than by this argument; the fourth and fifth are open. Allowing an empty match also makes the minimality claim partly analytic, which is conceded rather than hidden.

*Postulated.* Two, and both were folded away at some point and restored by audit.

A *realisation operator*. $\mathcal{C}$ is typed as a map out of $\mathcal{P}(G_t)$, and Remark 7.11 says outright that *a collapse needs something to select from.* An attempt to dissolve this — what matches writes, two rules matching make a bigger change, incoherent writes leave residual — does not survive: it trades collapse for union, which is a retained-branch treatment with the branches glued rather than a realisation, and the physics companion's measurement account needs exactly one continuation realised. It also mis-locates residual, which is defined as a *part* of a realised deformation and is per-rule, so it cannot carry a joint incompatibility between two individually admissible writes. The constructive companion is the evidence: its executor refuses that case as an explicit incompatibility rather than residualising it.

Between them, one thing about the economics that is neither postulate nor consequence, and which an earlier version of this remark got the status of wrong in both directions — first claiming it derived, then conceding it analytic. *A change is paid for in change*, and the status of that is category-preservation and not closure. An earlier version of this remark claimed closure and the claim does not survive, for reasons this paper supplies against itself.

The event order cannot loop. Axiom 0 makes enablement asymmetric — if one change makes another possible, the second does not thereby make the first possible — and Proposition 11.2 totally orders a frame's own writes, so an asymmetric transitive relation admits no cycle of any length. Proposition 13.7 does use the word *closure*, but of a *rule* loop, the same rules re-firing over distinct successive events; that is not the event order closing, and treating one as the other was an equivocation. What is left without a loop is a descending chain, which is a regress rather than a closed thing — and this paper already has the right word for where such a chain terminates. Remark 7.5 says a purchase buys *relocation rather than closure*, and the falsifiability section counts an in-frame procedure that settles rather than relocates as a single risk named four times. The claim made here was that move, called by the name the account reserves for its refusal. The physics companion is blunter still: it holds that this universe's entry *must come from outside*, a seed no frame derives from within.

What survives is weaker and is enough for the ledger. The funding is *category-preserving*: whatever funds a change is a change, in this frame or in a containing one, so no second kind of thing is admitted and the economics introduces no primitive beyond what the admission already brings. That is not a demonstration that the economics needs nothing; it is a demonstration that it needs nothing *new*. The regress relocates outward exactly as provenance does, which is what this account says everywhere else.

And the account has two unpaid entries, not one. That there is anything, which is the companion's claim and is not grounded here; and that anything happens, which the paragraph above calls a real addition not derived from anything here — and an entry not derived from anything here is unpaid, whatever follows from it once granted. An earlier version claimed only one and used the scarcity to argue that a costless change was ruled out because the account could not spend *ex nihilo* twice. Nothing forbids two brute facts, the argument was bookkeeping preference presented as a constraint, and it is withdrawn.

The falsifier goes with it. *Exhibit an economics that does not close* is not decidable: showing a funding source is not itself a change requires showing it at every containing level, and the physics companion says the relevant level is unrepresentable from within. What can be asked

instead is finite and is the surviving claim's own test — exhibit a change funded by something of a different kind, on inspection of the frame that made it and the container that sustains it, which is the two-level bound Proposition 7.4 already uses.

With that in place, one thing does remain postulated on the economics side. A *destroy/preserve distinction.* Proposition 7.6 exempts evaluation from cost because it preserves, so the operative criterion is not *a change costs* but *a change that destroys costs.* The reading that cost simply *is* change does not remove this: an information-preserving write is a change that destroys nothing — the physics companion says so of free continuation — so the two criteria are distinct and the account uses the second. The claim that the discarding class is the general one is empirical and is counted here.

*Not postulated, and a consequence rather than an axiom.* Axiom −1. *Of what* is the part this entry long omitted, carrying the revised label over an unrevised body: it follows from the companion's claim together with the measure, in the two steps Remark 2.1 sets out — to be is to stand in relation, a relation is what carries information, so a standpoint in no relation to what it views carries nothing about it and there is no informative view from nowhere. What the axiom denies was always an *operational* view from nowhere, and that qualifier is the whole of the claim rather than decoration on it. Below that derivation the older reading still applies and is not displaced by it. In this paper every use of it refuses an import — no frame-free denominator, no absolute threshold, no evaluator standing outside every frame — which is a discipline governing what the account may say, and a discipline is not a place this paper can fail. That is a claim about *this paper* and it does not generalise: in the groundings the axiom is used to license positive results (that two indiscernible particles are one, that a context-independent measure is available, that an inertial frame and a representational frame are the same kind of object), and there it is a commitment that can fail. The Narrativium companion already says so, locating the axiom's exposure in its own falsifier rather than in the substrate. So the honest statement is split: guard here, commitment there, and the groundings carry the risk — which is what Section 19 says of this account generally.

*A third tier.* Between postulate and consequence sit the results stated as hypotheses or marked undischarged: Minimal graph sufficiency, Discrete sufficiency, Located degradation, the Law of Graphic Equalisation itself, and the near-uniqueness of the cheap cut, which Section 16 calls an empirical posit and not a result. These are bets, and a two-tier ledger has nowhere to put them.

*What is offered as consequence*, and offered rather than proved: the residual's non-admission reading, the impossibility of complete self-transparency, the conditional that having time requires closure as well as inference, and the contingency of carvings. The frame interface is not among them, because this paper calls its two gates optimisations an efficient graph accretes under a budget rather than constituents of graphhood, which routes them through a selection pressure Section 16 declines to supply.

*How to read the count.* These reductions are re-descriptions — $X$ is a special case of $Y$ — and the criterion licensing them, that doing something is what a rule is, applies to anything this account posits. So a count driven to zero would be a theorem of the vocabulary rather than a measurement of the economy. What a surviving re-description does buy is narrower and real: it says two things cannot be varied independently, which constrains what a grounding may do. It does not reduce the number of ways the account can be wrong.

Nothing here exempts this paper from the rules it states. Where the ledger has been wrong it has been corrected against those rules and not against a lighter standard, and the record of that is in the companion on assessment.

That is not a further principle. It is Axiom −1 applied to the text: an account that stated its rules from outside its own scope would be speaking from nowhere, and there is nowhere to speak from. And it needs saying for the reason the axiom is numbered where it is (Remark 2.4) — *the import is free.* A reader defaults to hearing a claim as made about things rather than as

made by one of them, so the standpoint returns wherever it is not refused, and the refusal has to be repeated at each place it would return rather than stated once and relied on. That the account describes its own production needs no argument beyond the account — a description of everything includes the writing of it — and is not restated here.

*Remark* 2.7 (Where the rest of this programme sits). Two companions are easy to miss because nothing in the argument routes through them. *Is* carries the base this paper begins after, and is the only place the claim it rests on is argued rather than assumed; a reader who wants to attack the foundation should attack it there and not here. *Frames, Relation, and the Empty Limit* carries the material this paper's conclusion used to contain — what convergence under better-formedness converges *toward*, and why the limit of that direction is empty rather than a view from nowhere. It was moved out and, until now, was pointed at by nothing, which made it unfindable from the account it belongs to.

# Part II
# The substrate

## 3 The minimal graph

**Definition 3.1** (Graph)**.** *A graph is*

$$\boxed{G = (g, r, \Gamma),}$$

*where $g$ is represented state, $r$ is operative transformation structure, and $\Gamma$ is the admissibility grammar governing graph-originated transformations.*

*Nothing in that is typed, and the omission is the definition's content rather than its brevity. What the word* graph *denotes here is the floor — difference, and what differing consists in — while the typed object the word ordinarily calls to mind is derived and arrives with anything that runs (Remark 3.11). A reader supplies the typing regardless, which is why this is said here and again where it matters rather than left to the definition to carry alone.*

*Remark* 3.2 (Only $g$ is required; the triple is what a *running* world costs). The triple is not the minimum. Strip $r$ and $\Gamma$ and something remains: structure, with relations among its parts. Nothing *happens* in it — no transformation, so no collapse, no residual, and nothing it individuates — but it has not thereby become nothing, and it has not stopped being individuable by something else. What $r$ and $\Gamma$ buy is *occurrence*, and everything this account is about — change, collapse, observation, cost, experience — requires them. The triple is the price of a world in which anything happens rather than the price of there being anything, and Remark 7.11's "only that rules run is compulsory" should be read in that narrower sense.

A distinction is doing the work there. Being a frame is being individuated (Definition 6.2), and individuation is performed by the container, not by the thing: a boundary belongs to the frame that draws it. So a structure with no rules of its own is still a frame — something else instantiated its boundary — and what it lacks is not framehood but the capacity to individuate anything itself. Stripping $r$ does not leave "no frame", and reading it so would invalidate the companion result that reasons from a rock's being a frame to the universe's being one.

*Remark* 3.3 (The reference point, and what it is not). The definitional reference point for $g$ is a rock, and the anchor is ostensive because every candidate word — structure, extent, configuration — needs defining in turn. A rock has parts and relations among them; nothing about that structure is represented by anything; and at the grain at which one is a rock it originates no transformation. What happens to it is done by its container, and what happens

inside it happens in subframes at a finer grain. In its own terms it does not change: it merely is, and then later also merely is.

Three limits on that, because the anchor is more useful than the claim and the claim can be overstated.

It is a claim about a *grain* and not about a substance. A rock's atoms move and it weathers, both at grains other than the one at which it is a rock, so what is exhibited is an individuation.

It is not a proof that anything is $r$-free absolutely, and the machinery here suggests nothing is: Proposition 14.5 declines a floor, and at fine enough grain a rock's yield point — deformation absorbed up to a limit, fracture past it — is hard to distinguish from a change grammar sorting what coheres from what does not. The rock is offered as what $g$ looks like, not as an existence proof that pure $g$ occurs.

And the earlier claim that "every object has a grain at which nothing in it runs" asserted a floor this account elsewhere refuses. It is withdrawn. What holds is weaker and sufficient: for the objects one ordinarily handles, there is a grain at which one is not treating them as agents, and $g$ is the reading of them at that grain.

*Remark* 3.4 (An operational test, and what it cannot do)*.* There is a test for the reference point that is worth running even though it does not settle anything. *Throw it into space and see what happens.*

A rock thrown into space does nothing that is not done to it. It is struck by radiation, radiates heat away, and is altered over long enough — all by its container, and none of it registered, because registering requires rules to run. That criterion is the thing being tested, so this illustrates Remark 3.2 rather than checking it; the value is in what the test separates.

It separates three cases and not two. Throw an organism and something happens immediately: the rules it was running assumed conditions its container supplied, and the supply stops. Throw a spacecraft's computer and it continues, because it carries its supply. Nothing running, running with the container's support, running on supply brought along.

What it cannot do is distinguish *never ran* from *ran and stopped*. A rock and an organism killed on the way out are identical under it, so the test does not anchor $g$ and is not offered as doing so.

The intermediate case is instructive. Tardigrades desiccated before launch survived exposure to space vacuum in low Earth orbit and resumed on return, though survival fell sharply where vacuum was combined with full-spectrum solar ultraviolet (Jönsson et al., 2008). That is a structure whose rules stop firing and later fire again — which is *not* a structure entering $g$ and leaving it, since resuming requires the rules to have survived as present structure (Proposition 8.2). Rules present and not firing is a third condition, distinct from $g$ and from running alike, and the companion on mind names it directly. The slide from *has no r* to *fires no r* is easy to make and is not made here.

*Remark* 3.5 (On idealising, since this section has done a great deal of it)*.* Every construction above is an idealisation, which invites the obvious objection: an account whose axiom denies a view from nowhere has spent this section reasoning about frictionless rocks in vacuums. The criterion that answers it belongs to the method rather than to this paper and is stated in the companion *Is*: an idealisation is a frame, no frame is illegitimate, and what makes one cheap rather than expensive is whether what it removed is named and restorable.

Applied here, the removals are on the page. The rock is $g$ at the grain at which it is a rock, and the same passage says its atoms move and it weathers at other grains, so the removed structure can be put back. What Axiom $-1$ rejects is accordingly not an illegitimate simplification but an expensive habit — a simplification that has forgotten it made one, and is then read as a claim about the world rather than about a frame, at whatever that misreading later costs.

No parent pointer, world model, affordance catalogue, Narrative, Prospect, Value, or self-model is primitive. Such structures may exist in $g$ when the graph actually represents them.

**Hypothesis 3.6** (Minimal graph sufficiency)**.** *Any additional structure required only by a particular capability class is represented content or grounding, not a primitive of graphhood, unless a graph lacking it cannot participate in the basic realised transition relation.*

*Remark* 3.7 (The triple, unpacked in dependency order)*.* The three components of $G$ resolve into five constituents ordered by requirement, each presupposing the one before it:

$$\boxed{\text{nodes} \;\rightarrow\; \text{relations} \;\rightarrow\; \text{rules} \;\rightarrow\; \text{delta} \;\rightarrow\; \text{grammar.}}$$

*Nodes* are bare distinctions — the minimal *"difference which makes a difference"* (Bateson, 1972); a node alone carries almost no content. *Relations* structure nodes and require them as relata; this is where content lives, and a node's identity is its relations. *Rules* ($r$) act on relational structure and require relations to match. *Delta* is the change a rule writes and requires rules, since only a rule produces one. *Grammar* ($\Gamma$) determines which deltas are admissible and requires deltas to act on, which is why it is last. Nodes and relations are $g$; delta is $r$'s product, made explicit; grammar is $\Gamma$.

Two cautions. First, this constructive order does not contradict the relational primacy of Axiom −1: constructively nodes precede relations (relata come first), while semantically relations precede nodes (a node means nothing unheld by relations); both hold on different axes. Second, the order is a dependency partial order, not a temporal one — nodes are not a first *moment* but the least-dependent constituent, consistent with the absence of any substrate time (Section 13).

*Remark* 3.8 (The triple is a functional decomposition with nothing underneath it)*.* $g$, $r$, and $\Gamma$ are not three kinds of thing. Rules are graph data (nodes and relations), and admissibility is enforced by rules that decide admit-or-residual, so $r$ and $\Gamma$ are themselves graph data playing roles — transformation and gating — over the state $g$, which is graph data too. The triple decomposes function, and there is nothing beneath the functions for them to be modes of: what makes the three one is that each is graph data doing a job, not that each is a mode of some stuff that has jobs. Saying instead that *there is one substance, graph data* imports the bearer the companion removes by name (substance or intrinsic nature is on its candidate list, and the removal is reported as successful there), and does so in the sentence claiming to have decomposed it away. One substance is not the correction to three kinds of thing; *no* substance is. Three things follow. Admissibility is *mintable* like any rule, so what is admissible is not a fixed law but a growable set of rules a graph carries and extends. The reflection theorem is the special case of this homogeneity (the grammar, being rules, can act on itself), and it does not tower into a stack of meta-grammars, because gating and being-gated are one activity closing on itself rather than two. And the irreducible form of the substrate is *graph data that runs* — where the running is supplied by structure that is, in turn, graph data that runs (Section 14).

*Remark* 3.9 (Whether a node may have an edge to itself)*.* The question is basic and the papers had not answered it. The answer is not one thing.

*Nothing forbids the notation*, and the graph definition above says nothing either way.

*A self-edge cannot do the work of individuating.* The companion holds that to be is to stand in relation because a thing standing apart from nothing differs from nothing, and a single relatum with nothing to relate to is a failed case rather than a minimal one. A loop supplies no second term, so a node whose only edge is to itself is that failed case with an extra mark on it.

*And a self-edge does not cohere, and carries no information — which are one fact and not two.* Nothing stops a frame writing one; the point is what the write does. A relation holds two things apart, and with the same thing at both ends there is nothing to hold apart, so nothing coheres into a distinction. Correspondingly there are no bits: a relation is informative in the ordinary sense, as what it tells you about one end given the other, and this one gives you the thing given the thing, at conditional uncertainty zero. The failure to cohere and the absence of information are the same failure seen twice, because carrying information is what cohering into a distinction *is* here.

So a self-edge is not forbidden and not a cheaper relation. It is a write that is made and returns nothing into the frame, which is the decoherence case at its smallest, and it is the exact zero of the discipline the companion states with its prior art — do not introduce structure that buys no additional distinction. Definition 7.7 prices it accordingly: paid for in holding and search, returning nothing.

*In one place it is excluded rather than idle.* Axiom 0 makes enablement asymmetric — if one change makes another possible, the second does not thereby make the first — so in the enabling order a self-edge is the degenerate cycle and is ruled out with the rest.

*And it is not what self-reference means here.* A reflective graph (Definition 5.4) holds a *representation* of itself, which is distinct structure from what it represents; Proposition 14.5 has an operator be some other graph's running exposed. Self-reference in this account is always across a grain or a frame, never a loop at one node — which is why the regress goes downward without end rather than closing.

And the information reading says why that is not a limitation to be regretted. A model related to its subject by a self-edge would carry no bits; what makes a self-model informative is exactly that it is a *different and lesser* object than what it models, so that having it tells you something you did not have. *The incompleteness of a self-model is the condition of its being informative at all*, not a defect alongside its usefulness — which is the sharper form of the incompleteness results the companion on mind reports, and is why a frame that could hold a complete model of itself would gain nothing by holding it.

*Relative to what the ends are the same* is the part left unsaid above, and it is not a detail. A self-relation has both ends the same *as drawn by whatever individuates them*, and individuation is performed by the container (Remark 3.2). So a loop at one node is a verdict of the frame holding it, not a property the structure carries on its own: a container that discriminates more finely sees two things where the inner frame saw one, and what was a self-relation there is an ordinary relation here, carrying bits. The zero is real and is real *in that frame.*

Which gives the frame-relative form of the result, and it is the useful one. *What does not cohere in a frame does not exist in it, and no appeal against that verdict is available inside it.* A containing structure that the current frame cannot resolve is not a thing here that fails a test; it is not here, and it never comes to be here without the frame's individuation changing — which is a transition, not a discovery. That is Axiom $-1$ applied to existence and not a weakening of the account.

It does not reinstate what Remark 2.6 rejected, and the difference matters, the two being easily run together. What was rejected there was existence turning on *whether some grammar admits it*, which would make the unobserved tree's relation to its forest wait on a licence. Nothing waits on a licence here. What is being said is only that a distinction not drawn in a frame is not available in it, which is what having an aperture means. The companion, having no frames at all, cannot state any of this and correctly does not: at that level the careful form is that a description which does not cohere picks out nothing, and there is no current frame for it to fail to cohere in.

*Remark* 3.10 (Coherence, not relation, is the criterion)*.* The self-edge result bore on the companion's first proposition, which as worded the degenerate case passes: *anything that exists as a determinate something stands in at least one relation* is satisfied by a thing standing in a relation to itself, and the previous remark establishes that such a relation carries nothing, so the letter was met and the point was not. The companion now carries a second proposition for it, and what follows is the same content in this paper's vocabulary rather than an outstanding repair. *To exist is to cohere*, where cohering is the relation carrying something — a fact about one end given the other that was not already had. The three cases differ only in that quantity: nothing related carries nothing and has no relation to carry it; a relation only to oneself is a relation carrying nothing; two things related carry something, which is why that case is the only one of the three that is anything at all. The first two are descriptions picking out nothing rather

than things that fail a test — the companion is careful about this and it is worth being careful about here, since a quantity sorted across cases invites reading the empty ones as populated. *Relation is necessary and coherence is what makes it sufficient.*

Observation remains unnecessary for existence, which the companion already says, and coherence is what it was leaving open by saying only that — a difference is carried whether or not anything comes to register it, and registering is a separate event the companion's own subject matter cannot perform. And *cohere* is the logician's word used in frame. A consistency check is exactly what is being run, and this paper has been running it throughout under the name Γ. Residual is inadmissibility (Definition 3.17), which is a frame declining to hold two things together — so the mechanism was already here and only the identification was missing.

One boundary on that, since without it the identification would prove too much. Frame-relative consistency belongs *here*, where there are frames; it cannot be what the companion's base runs on, because a criterion for existing that required a frame would index existing to frames, which Remark 2.6 rejects on exactly that ground. At the base the degenerate cases are degenerate *structurally* — what a relation to oneself reports about one end given the other was already given, for anything or nothing — and Γ is that floor made operative once there are frames to operate it, not a replacement for it. The companion has no rules of any kind, and does not need them: nothing there *enforces* coherence, because not existing is not an outcome anything has to bring about. Rules are what *making* requires, and the companion's question is what can exist rather than what can be created — a distinction it draws with the one-node case, which can be created and does not thereby exist. What this paper adds is a grammar of what may follow, which arrives with the happening and is paid for in the ledger.

Reading the two as one scale places the degenerate case correctly. What cannot be held together at all is one end; what is held so trivially that having it tells nothing is the other; and a self-relation is the *second*. One note on the word, since it was in use here before it was a criterion. Where these papers already say *incoherent* — a grain that cannot hold what entered it and must split, a self that ceases to hold together, a superframe re-cohering after a change — they mean the end where holding is *impossible*. That is one of the two ends, and the criterion above covers both, so a reader carrying the established sense into the companion's proposition will look for a contradiction in the self-relation case and find none. There is none to find: that case fails at the other end. The widening is deliberate and is noted here rather than left to be discovered.

That is why the self-relation's failure is emptiness rather than prohibition — nothing rules it out, and there is nothing in it — and why Section 19 has no commitment forbidding one. The relativity is load-bearing in the same way twice over: consistency without a frame is the unasked question that shortest-description without a vocabulary is, and Axiom −1 is what answers both.

*Remark* 3.11 (What plurality forces, and what it does not)*.* The measure of the previous remark applies to a *pair* of differences as readily as to the two ends of one. Doing so forces something — though less than a first statement of this remark claimed.

Two differences differing in nothing are not two. Where nothing tells them apart the second carries no bits the first did not, which is the previous result read across a pair rather than along one edge. So a plurality *requires* that its members differ, and requires whatever that differing consists in. This is the argument that forces existence to be graph and not a second one: a plurality requires whatever makes the plurality possible, and that is not a further posit but the content of there being more than one. Stated so it needs no relata — it is difference among differences, and an earlier version speaking of relations joining the same relata was giving a frame's rendering of it.

The objection is that the differentiating structure looks eliminable. Reify it — make the relation a node and hang its ends off it — and it appears to dissolve into more graph. It does not. The reified node carries several relations of its own, at least to its ends, and those must be told apart or the reification has not said which end is which. The problem is *reproduced* at the new level, not removed, and again at the next. So it is not a convenience bought over some

cheaper form lacking it: it is where distinguishability sits at whatever level one stops, and it descends without closing for the reason self-reference does.

What that forces is smaller than a *type*, and *the partition is forced; the names are not* overreaches by exactly that margin, leaving a partition on the forced side — and a partition is a grouping into classes, a class is a sameness holding across occurrences, and a sameness holding across occurrences is a concept. *Distinctness is forced; sameness is not.* The asymmetry is not stipulated. That two differences are not one is given with there being two; that two are of a kind says they are interchangeable in some respect, and a respect is a frame's. Section 1 says as much already in holding that functional identity is the whole of what identity could mean without a view from nowhere. So what is forced is that they differ in some further way. Organising those ways into kinds, naming the kinds, and fixing which side of one is the *yes* are three further things, each supplied and none given.

None of that makes typing absent, and reading it that way would be the opposite error to the one being corrected. *Types are emergent.* A plurality forces its members to differ; anything that operates over them repeatedly treats some alike, and an operator treating two differences alike is what their alikeness consists in — so kinds arise wherever a plurality is run over, which is wherever anything runs. Every graph anyone meets is therefore typed, and none is typed at the floor. The defect is never that types are present; it is only ever the ordering, taking as given what arrives derived.

Which is why the import stays nearly free even from the bare word *graph*. A reader supplies types on hearing it, because in every field that uses the word they are there, and is almost always right to. *That is the dangerous case and not the safe one.* A false import is refuted by a counterexample and does not survive; a true-but-derived one is refuted by nothing, and passes every check that asks whether it is so. The remedy cannot be a better lens and is the axiom's own: refuse it where it would return, repeatedly, rather than once and thereafter relied upon.

The descent is worth setting out in order, because each step looks like the floor when seen from the one above it. There is a difference. Reading its sides as *two things* draws boundaries, and a boundary belongs to the frame that draws it (Remark 3.2). Reading two differences as *the same kind* adds an identity across occurrences. Naming the kinds adds nothing measurable at all (Shannon, 1948). Fixing a polarity adds less than that, there being no *yes* to be distinguished where nothing has yet been distinguished. Concepts, names, signs and polarities stand on the supplied side together; *only the difference does not.*

Which says from below why the previous remark came out as it did. A self-relation asserts an identity, and an identity is what a frame supplies rather than what a difference gives — so it carries nothing, not because a special case was found for it, but because it asserts the one thing no difference contains.

Two exposures, for the two halves. A formalism carrying a genuine plurality with nothing at any level telling its members apart would refute the forcing, and the reification regress is why none is expected. A sameness readable off a difference with no respect supplied would refute the limit — and that second exposure is not new here. Section 19 already carries it as *frame-relative identity*, failing if sameness and persistence are derivable from $(g, r, \Gamma)$ alone without individuation, which is this limit stated before it had an argument. What this remark adds is the argument, not the commitment.

**Definition 3.12** (Grounding)**.** *A* grounding *is a particular assignment of rule content and initial conditions to the substrate — one* $(g, r, \Gamma)$ *with its laws and its starting configuration fixed — together with the domain it is taken to model. The substrate is what every grounding shares; a grounding is what any one of them adds. Claims made about the substrate are accordingly claims about all groundings, and are correspondingly weak; claims made within a grounding carry that grounding's contingent rule content and are where this account's falsifiable commitments mostly sit.*

### 3.1 Discrete sufficiency

**Hypothesis 3.13** (Discrete sufficiency)**.** *Every quantity required internally by the present substrate can be represented by discrete distinguishable states at the operative frame and resolution.*

A convenient coordinate is an integer index $n \in \mathbb{Z}$ with grounding

$$x = \phi_{\mathcal{F}}(n).$$

The map may be nonlinear, nonuniform, state-dependent, and dynamically re-quantised. Thus "integer-valued" means discretely indexed, not globally unit-spaced.

**Proposition 3.14** (Arbitrary refinement does not imply continuity)**.** *A dimension may admit arbitrarily fine or dynamically changing quantisation without requiring the theory to posit realised values at every real-valued intermediate point.*

*Remark* 3.15. A continuous containing supergraph is neither required nor excluded. Existing continuous physical theories may ground or contain this substrate without contradiction.

*Remark* 3.16 (Discrete sufficiency is not fundamental discreteness)*.* These are distinct claims with distinct falsifiers and must not be conflated. Discrete sufficiency is the claim above, and it fails if some observable consequence internal to the substrate cannot be represented discretely, at the operative frame and resolution, without loss — a claim decidable in-frame. *Fundamental discreteness* — that the containing or pre-relational substrate is itself discrete — would instead concern a fact about the pre-graph substrate that the epistemic boundary above places outside the theory's reach, which is precisely why it is not asserted.

### 3.2 Admissible possibility

Let $\mathcal{P}(G_t)$ denote the structured family of immediate continuations admitted by the present graph and its current relations.

**Definition 3.17** (Admissible continuation)**.** *A continuation $\delta$ belongs to $\mathcal{P}(G_t)$ iff it is expressible in the current graph vocabulary, satisfies the relevant antecedent conditions, and is admissible under the operative grammar for the transformation class in question.*

The theory does not require a particular algorithm for constructing $\mathcal{P}(G_t)$. This extensional separation between graph transformation as a mathematical relation and any particular rewriting algorithm follows the general discipline of algebraic graph transformation, where rewrite rules and admissible transformations can be studied independently of one concrete executor (Ehrig et al., 2006).

**Definition 3.18** (Partial transformation)**.** *Write*

$$G \oplus \delta \rightharpoonup G'$$

*for the partial realised transformation relation. Undefinedness means that $\delta$ does not produce a structurally valid successor under the stated conditions. No ontological FAIL state is required.*

## 4 Collapse and realised history

**Definition 4.1** (Collapse)**.** *Collapse is the frame-relative passage from a pre-realisation possibility structure to realised continuation:*

$$\boxed{\mathcal{C}_t : \mathcal{P}(G_t) \rightsquigarrow G_{t+1}.}$$

*It is not identified with deliberative choice.*

The term is inherited from quantum measurement theory, where a formal distinction is made between a pre-measurement state and the realised measurement record; the historical lineage includes the von Neumann measurement scheme and later relative-state formulations (von Neumann, 1955; Everett, 1957). This paper does not claim that every grounding reproduces the full quantum formalism; it claims that the possibility-to-realisation distinction is load-bearing.

**Definition 4.2** (History)**.** *The realised history of a frame is*

$$\mathcal{H} = G_0 \xrightarrow{\mathcal{C}_0} G_1 \xrightarrow{\mathcal{C}_1} G_2 \to \cdots .$$

*Remark* 4.3 (Collapse is a local write, not a global tick). The subscripts on $\mathcal{C}_t$ index a frame's own succession and must not be read as a shared clock. A collapse is a *local realisation* — a rule writing a delta — and it is the only kind of event the substrate has (its synchrony or asynchrony with other collapses is set by coupling, Remark 11.3). Between writes nothing happens: an unwritten frame produces no change, so it takes no new position in the order the changes carry (Section 11), and no time passes for it. There is accordingly no global step in which every frame advances together; frames whose collapses are not related through a boundary are simply unordered with respect to one another (Section 11). "Momentum" — the standing structure a frame carries, persisting without a distinct write — is therefore the absence of an event, not a repeated one; a delta is a write *to* that structure, not the structure itself, and the Narrative-momentum paper names its operative history-bearing form the Narrative, so that to change course is literally to write the Narrative. The picture of a single global present sweeping forward is exactly the represented time dimension of Axiom 0 mistaken for substrate structure.

# 5 The Law of Graphic Equalisation

**Hypothesis 5.1** (Law of Graphic Equalisation)**.** *For realised graph $G_t$, present graph structure determines admissible continuation structure $\mathcal{P}(G_t)$. Interaction and collapse realise successor $G_{t+1}$, and that realised successor becomes the antecedent graph for the next local transition. Recursive dynamics are generated by repeated equalisation between present represented structure, admissible transformation, containing constraints, and realised continuation.*

Thus

$$\boxed{G_t \to \mathcal{P}(G_t) \xrightarrow{\mathcal{C}_t} G_{t+1} \to \mathcal{P}(G_{t+1}) \xrightarrow{\mathcal{C}_{t+1}} G_{t+2} \to \cdots .}$$

## 5.1 The antecedent-state principle

**Proposition 5.2** (Antecedent-state principle)**.** *The conditions under which a transition is admissible are functions of its antecedent state. A consequence that exists only because a transition has occurred cannot retroactively serve as an antecedent cause of that same transition.*

**Corollary 5.3** (No self-authorisation from future state)**.** *A reflective transformation of $r$ or $\Gamma$ may alter the successor graph, but newly installed structure cannot authorise the transition by which it first comes into existence.*

## 5.2 Recursion and reflection

**Definition 5.4** (Reflective graph)**.** *A graph is reflective over structure $X \subseteq G$ when $X$ is represented in the graph and graph-originated transformations may take that representation as an operand.*

**Theorem 5.5** (The grammar is the loop)**.** *If $\Gamma$ is represented as graph structure and admits transformations whose operand is that representation of $\Gamma$, then the resulting recursion is not a separate loop acting on the grammar. The grammar acting on itself is the loop.*

*Proof.* The transition $\Gamma_t \to \Gamma_{t+1}$ is itself a graph transition licensed from the antecedent graph. No additional external operator is required to create the recursion. The self-applicable grammar and the compound loop are therefore two descriptions of the same transition structure. □

# 6 Situated graphs and world boundaries

**Definition 6.1** (World boundary)**.** *A boundary $\mathcal{B}_{W:G}$ is the relation through which containing frame $W$ can alter situated graph $G$ and through which graph-originated deformation can participate in interactions represented by $W$.*

A graph need not contain a pointer to $W$; containment belongs to the containing frame. A situated graph is a *subset* of $W$, not a thing separate from it: the boundary demarcates which subset is the graph, and self and container are one graph divided by individuation, not two substances (Proposition 6.5).

The boundary is a relation, and that fixes the type of the term this paper uses most.

**Definition 6.2** (Frame)**.** *A* frame *is an instantiated boundary relation — the edge $\mathcal{B}_{W:G}$ itself, and not the subgraph $G$ it demarcates. The subgraph is the relatum; the frame is the relation. To individuate is to instantiate such an edge, which is why individuation is per frame rather than a fact about the graph.*

**Corollary 6.3** (Frame and dimension are one edge type in two roles)**.** *A dimension is the same construction read from the other end. The boundary $\mathcal{B}_{W:G}$ is a dimension of $W$ — one of the properties along which $W$ separates what it contains — and each dimension $W$ instantiates is a frame to the values it separates. So* frame *and* dimension *name two roles one edge type plays relative to another edge, not two kinds of thing, and the asymmetry between them is positional in the same way that the asymmetry between a parent and a child is.*

Definition 12.1's four states are accordingly the states of an *edge*: NULL is the edge's non-existence, *undetermined* its admissibility without collapse, *undisclosed* a collapse outside this frame's aperture, and *resolved* a collapse within it. A node has no admissible-but-uncollapsed state; an edge does, and Definition 3.17 is about exactly that. Frame-relative termination (Section 10.1) and the revocation of a dimension are then one operation — the container ceasing to instantiate the relation — which is why the Narrativium paper observes revocation occurring with $\Delta g = 0$: nothing in the contained state need change for the edge to go.

The unification is not this paper's invention: the substrate's own implementation has no frame primitive at all, its grammar quantifying over edge types, and a frame there is a selection of dimensions. And the convenience reading of a frame as *the subgraph* is used throughout these papers, including above; it is shorthand for the relatum, and where a claim turns on the difference the relation is meant.

**Proposition 6.4** (Admissibility is self-governance, not armour)**.** *$\Gamma_G$ constrains graph-originated transformations of $G$. It does not give $G$ a veto over world-caused change represented through $\mathcal{B}_{W:G}$.*

Hence

$$\boxed{\text{self-originated transformation} \neq \text{outward influence} \neq \text{inbound world forcing.}}$$

**Proposition 6.5** (Self-change is direct and gated; a graph is a subset of its container)**.** *A graph changes itself and its subgraphs directly. Self-change is real, but it is rule-governed, with its own cost and limits (an instance of the non-uniform writeability of Remark 7.12); a substrate's plasticity is exactly the rules for how its rules may change. What a graph does* not *do is change its container directly: the container applies deformations to it — being observed* is *being so*

*deformed — and gates its changes through its own change grammar (Proposition 8.3). But a situated graph is a* subset *of its container, not a thing set against it, so a self-change is already a change in the container, in the region that is the graph, propagating outward through whatever couples it to the rest. "Change only yourself" is therefore not isolation but the mechanism of outward effect: a graph changes its container by changing the part of it that it is.*

Two things follow. This is one *self-similar* operation — a graph changing its own subsets — run at every level: the container does to the graph exactly what the graph does to its subgraphs (Section 14). And it dissolves the agency/determinism dichotomy: a subset changing itself (agency, in the graph's frame) and the whole changing that subset (determined, in the container's frame) are one event read at two scales, so both hold without contradiction. The reflection theorem is this self-change of the rules; that it is bounded rather than free is because a change to the rules currently executing is heavily constrained — the worst case of the concurrency of Section 11, seen through the frame-limited view of Section 17 — which is what plasticity's limits are. Governance can tighten to exclusion: where a container's admissibility admits no such self-change, that change is available only across the boundary, from the container.

**Proposition 6.6** (Coupling is configuration, not architecture)**.** *That distinct instances individuate — diverge, each minting its own residual, the part of a change a containing grammar does not admit (Definition 8.1) — is a consequence of their running on* separate *containing frames, not a necessity. Where several instances are subgraphs of one* shared *containing frame, each instance's self-change is a change in that shared frame, in its own region (Proposition 6.5), which then deforms the others as their common container: instances that are subsets of one container propagate to each other through it. This is the same machinery as being an individual, with the container shared rather than private.*

Coupling is therefore a continuous setting of the shared boundary's aperture and change grammars (Proposition 7.1), not a binary: sharing only generators leaves each instance its own moment-to-moment state (and already removes the per-substrate build floor of Proposition 7.13), while sharing all operative structure is one individual over many bodies, with SELF and SUPERGRAPH identity (Section 6.1) dialling independently. Nothing in the substrate fixes the setting. The symmetric fact is that a shared containing frame is equally a shared residual and a shared forcing, so the same coupling that shares understanding gives shared corruption, container-level coercion, and collective termination-failure the same reach; "at what coupling, and with what guarding" is the substantive question, and it is an engineering one rather than a question of possibility.

## 6.1 SELF and SUPERGRAPH identity

**Definition 6.7** (SELF identity)**.** *SELF identity is the continuity of the graph as a whole — its rules together with the state they act on — across realised transitions. A graph is the same self while its present remains congruous with its own history: if its rules changed abruptly, the structure carried forward would no longer cohere with what produced it, and that incongruity is the discontinuity. Represented self-description — content inside g by which a graph identifies itself — is one optional part of this and not the whole of it; a graph may have SELF identity without representing itself at all.*

**Definition 6.8** (SUPERGRAPH identity)**.** *For graph $G$ individuated in frame $W$,*

$$\iota_{W:G} = \mathrm{Id}_W(G)$$

*is the identity relation under which $W$ tracks that situated instance.*

SELF and SUPERGRAPH identity are distinct types. A copy can preserve SELF identity while receiving a new SUPERGRAPH identity, and one SUPERGRAPH identity may persist through extensive changes to internal state and self-description.

**Theorem 6.9** (No frame-free identity)**.** *The substrate alone does not determine whether two represented instances are the same graph independently of an individuating frame.*

# Part III
# Frames, economics, and failure

## 7 The frame interface and its economics

The boundary of Section 6 can be characterised by what actually crosses it and what it costs, and the characterisation is unexpectedly thin.

**Proposition 7.1** (One interface, two gates)**.** *A situated graph meets its containing frame through a single relation, and what an observation from that frame delivers is not distinct in kind from what the containing frame imposes: to a subgraph, being observed* is *being deformed by its container. That one relation is gated twice, by the same kind of admissibility grammar on its two faces — the* aperture grammar $\Gamma_a$ *on the input and the* change grammar $\Gamma_c$ *on the output:*

$$\underbrace{\textit{aperture}}_{\Gamma_a} \longrightarrow \underbrace{\textit{rules}}_{r} \longrightarrow \underbrace{\textit{change}}_{\Gamma_c}.$$

$\Gamma_a$ *limits, by grain, which of the container's deformation enters the rules;* $\Gamma_c$ *determines which of the rules' realised deltas cohere into the container and which remain as residual (Proposition 8.3). Both are faces of the frame's one grammar* $\Gamma$*, and instantiate for a specific container* $W$ *as* $\Gamma_{W_a}$ *and* $\Gamma_{W_c}$*; it is* $\Gamma_{W_c}$*, the change face, that the residual proposition uses. Execution runs between the two.*

The input face is named often enough in these papers to be worth defining rather than assumed.

**Definition 7.2** (Aperture)**.** *A frame's* aperture *is its input gate* $\Gamma_a$ *together with what that gate fixes: which dimensions it can separate along at all, how finely it separates within each (its resolution, per dimension, for which this paper also uses* grain*), and how far along each it reaches. The three are properties of one edge — existence, grain, and extent — and are named separately because they vary independently, not because they are different kinds of limit. What falls outside an aperture on any of the three is* absent *to that frame rather than held-but-unresolved.*

The output face is the same kind of object and takes the same treatment.

**Definition 7.3** (Change grammar)**.** *A frame's* change grammar $\Gamma_c$ *is its output gate: it determines which of the realised deltas its rules produce cohere into the containing frame and which do not. What it declines has entered the frame and been operated on, so it is* residual *(Definition 8.1) rather than absent, and it persists in place rather than being discarded.* $\Gamma_a$ *and* $\Gamma_c$ *are the two faces of one grammar* $\Gamma$ *on one boundary edge, and the asymmetry between them is which direction they gate, not what kind of thing they are.*

This distinguishes two ways a candidate is excluded, with opposite consequences. What falls below the aperture grammar $\Gamma_a$ never enters and is therefore *absent* — it is simply absent to the frame — there is nothing there for it to hold or to be disturbed by — rather than residual. What $\Gamma_c$ does not admit has entered, been operated on, and cannot cohere; it is residual, and it persists in place, re-encountered on each merge (Corollary 8.4). The first is a limit of perception, the second a limit of expression, and phenomena of the "stuck, repeating" kind belong exclusively to the second.

**Proposition 7.4** (Costs are paid; where and how is not fixed by the substrate)**.** *The substrate's economic commitment is narrow and should be stated before the specific one that follows, because the specific one is often mistaken for it.* A change is paid for. *Which frame pays, in what currency, at what point, and under what discipline is* not *fixed here — it is rule content, and implementations differ over it freely. And what the substrate forbids is nothing: a change paid for nowhere is admissible here, exactly as a frame with no economics is (Remark 2.6). The claim is not a prohibition but an observed universal* — every change anyone has traced has been paid for somewhere — *and stating it as a prohibition, as an earlier version did, gave it a quantifier over all frames that no one can discharge and that Axiom -1 denies anyone the standpoint for. Free lunches are permitted. None has been found, in any frame that has been measured, and that is the whole of the claim.*

The correction this repeatedly needs is always the same shape: an assignment of the cost mistaken for the invariant. Whether an inadmissible write propagates or coheres to a value, whether a failure is caught or unwound, whether the check is explicit at every call or deferred to a marked path — each is a convention, each puts the cost somewhere different, and none is the substrate speaking. The invariant is only that the cost is somewhere.

And the floor is not a claim about magnitude. You may pay *less* for the same result — that is compression, and Proposition 16.2 is about structures pushed toward it. You may pay and thereby be able to do *more* — that is spend-and-gain, and it is why expenditure is not loss. What is unattested is neither of these but the third thing — unattested rather than excluded, since Proposition 7.4 is an observed universal and not a prohibition: getting the result without anyone having paid.

The everyday form makes the mechanism visible and is worth stating, because apparent freeness is common and always has the same structure. *An all-you-can-eat buffet is free at the point of consumption and is nonetheless paid.* The cost was moved — to a different transaction, borne by another party, amortised across many, settled earlier in time — and the moving is itself structure that somebody holds and maintains. Every case of something appearing free resolves this way on inspection, and the appearance is not an illusion in the frame that has it: at the table the next plate genuinely costs nothing, which is Axiom -1 showing up in an ordinary place. What is unavailable is the view in which nobody paid.

That is a real commitment rather than a definitional one, and its falsifier is stated with the others: exhibit a realised change whose cost is absent at every frame, rather than relocated to one that was not being looked at.

*Remark* 7.5 (The cost of a task approaches zero, and the total does not). The preceding proposition has a limiting form that sounds like a contradiction of it and is not. *A well-formed frame's tasks approach zero cost.* Two readings hold and both matter.

The weaker is about overhead. Well-formedness is paying for nothing that does no work, so as a frame approaches it the *excess* above what the task requires goes to zero. Cost does not: a change is floored (Remark 7.8), and no arrangement gets beneath the floor. What vanishes is the difference between what is paid and what must be.

The stronger is about absorption and is the interesting one. A frame meeting something that coheres with what it already holds writes nothing, and what forces no write costs nothing — so *the cost of a task falls toward zero as the task becomes held*, and the floor does not bind because the floor is on change and a fully absorbed task is not a change. That is what expertise is, mechanically: not a faster way of paying but a task that has stopped costing.

It composes with the previous proposition rather than escaping it, and the composition is the same shape as the buffet. Fluency is free at the point of use because it was paid for during acquisition; the learner paid, the expert does not, and they are the same frame at two times. Every case of a task costing nothing resolves into a case of it having been paid for earlier, which is prepayment rather than exemption.

None of this is about cognition in particular. *Task* here means any change a frame has to pay for, and the reading applies to a forager, a firm, a lineage and a protocol alike — which yields the distinction that does the work.

A cost can be moved *sideways*, to a peer frame. That is externalising, and it buys a real local advantage. Whether that advantage is temporary depends on the peer: one able to register the cost responds, and the response is the continuous paid change of Remark 7.10. A peer that cannot register it — the case treated later in this paper — does not, and there the advantage persists for as long as the signal fails to return, which may be indefinitely. Nothing is reduced by a lateral move; the total is what it was, redistributed, and the advantage lasts exactly as long as the asymmetry does.

Reduction proper comes from moving *up* — acquiring structure at a level that did not previously carry it, so that what each unit below must pay falls. A shared protocol replaces pairwise translation; a medium of exchange replaces the search for a double coincidence of wants; a held record replaces each generation re-deriving; multicellularity stops every cell solving the whole problem. In each the task did not get cheaper for the participant by cleverness at the participant's level. It got cheaper because something above it now holds structure that was previously being paid for repeatedly, everywhere, by everyone.

Two honest qualifications, the second of which matters more.

The claim should be sized rather than announced, because two literatures have already written it for their own domains. Coase (1937) explains the firm as coordination moved up out of the market exactly when the market's transaction costs exceed the hierarchy's, and Maynard Smith and Szathmáry (1995) read the history of life as a sequence of such moves — replicating molecules to populations in compartments, unlinked replicators to chromosomes, then to cells, to eukaryotes, to multicellularity, to sociality, to language. Their ladder is theirs and the criterion is not: they unify the transitions by changes in how information is stored and transmitted, and no cost comparison appears in that book, so what is imported from them is the sequence while the *when* is Coase's alone. What is offered here is that these are one move rather than two analogous ones, which is the same contribution this account makes elsewhere and no larger.

And moving up is not a free lunch either, which is Proposition 7.4 applied one level out. The higher structure must be built, which is paid, and then *maintained*, which is paid continuously — so the move trades a recurring per-task cost for a recurring maintenance cost and wins only where the ratio favours it.

That ratio is necessary and not sufficient. *A favourable ratio does not make the move available.* The transition is paid up front, out of what the frame holds now, so a frame can face an arrangement that would plainly reduce its costs and be unable to reach it — the boots theory of socioeconomic unfairness is this at the scale where it is most legible, the durable purchase that would end a recurring cost being precisely what the recurring cost prevents accumulating.

This is not a new mechanism and should be named where it already lives. In the companions' terms the better arrangement is a point in the frame's reachable geometry — visible, representable, genuinely accessible as a future — whose required deformation exceeds the Narrativium measured for the frame. One terminological caution, since this paper and its companions divide the words differently: what is called *capability* here is the gates, while the companions use that word for the reachable set, which is what this section calls *accessibility* — the Narrativium paper does so following Sen, and the Seldon paper does so without the borrowing, where a situation can be a trap and a capability at once. The distinction drawn is the same in all of them; only the labels differ, and a reader moving between them should expect that. There is a third, narrower use in the companion on assessment, where a capability is a shipped unit with its own tests; it is stipulated there and is not this word. It fails the feasibility gate and not the desirability one. *Accessible futures with insufficient capacity to reach them* is the general form, and the boots case is its most legible instance.

Stating it that way exposes a distinction this material needed, and the right names for it are

already in use: *capability* against *accessibility*. Capability is what a frame's gates admit — what it can represent and what it can do. Accessibility is what it can *reach* from where it stands, given what it holds to spend. A disclosure moves a gate and changes capability; whether the reachable point can then be crossed to depends on the Narrativium measured for the frame. The companion defining that quantity types it as a *capacity* rather than as a cost, and keeps measurement and expenditure distinct; the phrasing here follows it.

That also corrects the class named a moment ago, which was drawn too narrowly. An information hazard is a *capability* change whose negative sign is admissible in the reference frame — the qualifier is developed in Section 10, where it is load-bearing — and it is not the whole of what alters a frame's prospects — an accessibility failure alters them with the capability untouched. The boots case is exactly that: nothing about the gates prevents buying durable boots, and the arrangement is nonetheless out of reach. So a frame can have the gate open and the capacity absent, in which case the arrangement is fully understood and permanently out of reach, and information is not the binding constraint — which is why telling such a frame more accomplishes nothing. The converse is the ordinary case for which disclosure is the right intervention. An intervention aimed at capability when accessibility *alone* binds, or at accessibility when the gate alone is shut, does nothing in either direction, and the two are routinely confused because both present as a frame failing to do the obvious thing. Where *both* bind the case is different and is treated below.

The coupling described below makes the order matter as well as the target. Because aperture is purchased, an accessibility failure becomes a capability failure over time — the frame that cannot reach also comes to see less — so where both bind, relieving accessibility first restores the capability that was lost to it, while supplying capability first is spent on a frame that still cannot act on it. That is a claim about sequence rather than about generosity, and it is the practical consequence of the two being orthogonal at an instant and coupled over one.

The orthogonality is clean at a point in time and does not stay clean, because *aperture is itself purchased*. Holding a wider aperture or a longer horizon is standing structure a frame pays to maintain, so anything consuming capacity narrows it — which bears on the companion on mind, where a frame under stress becomes manipulable by having its horizon shortened rather than its judgement impaired. That paper gives its own account of the shortening; what is offered here is a different one, in this account's terms, and the two have not been reconciled. The narrowing needs no special stress machinery. It is the ordinary consequence of the charge for something else having been paid, which is a change in what is reachable rather than a level drawn down.

That prediction is domain-general and dose-dependent, and it has been measured in the least convenient case for the account's comfort. Scarcity itself consumes the capacity: the same farmers tested before and after harvest differ substantially in general cognitive performance, with the deficit attributable to the scarcity rather than to nutrition or to who they are (Mani et al., 2013). The narrowing has a name in that literature — *tunnelling*, with the capacity it consumes called a bandwidth tax (Mullainathan and Shafir, 2013) — and again the contribution here is not the phenomenon but the reason: a frame's aperture is standing structure it pays to hold, so a demand on capacity narrows it by the same mechanism that any other spend would.

Which makes the trap compound rather than merely bind. The frame that cannot afford the move up is, for the same reason, holding a narrower aperture — so the arrangement it cannot reach is also one it is less able to represent, and each shortfall deepens the other. *Insufficient capacity does not only prevent the move; it degrades the instrument that would identify the move as worth making.* An account that treated aperture as given would predict a frame stuck but clear-sighted, and that is not what is found.

Which makes the up-front cost of a transition a structural quantity rather than an accounting detail: it decides who can move up at all, and it is why the capacity to make the move is distributed quite differently from the incentive to make it. That is why such moves are not

universal, why they are reversed when the maintained structure stops being worth its upkeep, and why the ones that persist are the ones whose maintenance is cheaper than what they displaced.

There is a third cost before those two and it is the one most easily left out of an account like this, because it is invisible in retrospect. The higher structure has to be *found*. Building and maintaining are what you pay once you know what to build, and knowing that is not given — so the search is paid too, mostly by whoever does not find anything.

The order is not forced either, and the account should not imply it is. A structure may be found by accident and explained afterwards, and frequently is; explanation is not what licenses the structure but what is done with it once held. The biological form of this is ordinary and named — something arising under one pressure and later turned to a use it was not reached for — and the industrial form is familiar enough to have become a single word. *Research and development are not separable*, and the reason is structural rather than institutional: you cannot establish what the higher structure is except by attempting to build it, since a specification you cannot build from is exactly the one that turns out to have been incomplete.

Which is this paper's own machinery arriving from a third direction. The boundary is known only by crossing it (Remark 9.4); the dependents of a thing are legible only from outside it (Remark 9.5); and now, the structure that would reduce a cost is findable only by trying to construct it. *The test and the change are one operation*, stated three times in three places, and R&D as a single term is that fact already noticed by people who had to pay for it.

One limit keeps this from being a monotone slide to nothing, and it is in the four costs already. Driving the cost of tasks down means holding more, and what is held is searched: the third cost rises exactly as the first falls. So a frame does not approach zero total cost by absorbing everything — it trades per-task cost against search, which is why aperture is a live setting rather than a value to maximise, and why a frame that retained all it ever met would pay the most rather than the least.

**Proposition 7.6** (Cost characteristically reduces to the write)**.** *In the substrate as characterised here, the boundary relation itself is free; the standing structure persisting is free* to the frame — *whether it is free* simpliciter *is set by the rules of the superframes, which may sustain a frame without charge or require a write to keep it standing, and the substrate does not decide between them; the operation that costs is a delta that writes over that structure, and r is what writes. Free here means information-preserving rather than absent — evaluating a rule is itself a write, and is unpaid because it destroys nothing (Remark 7.9). To that extent*

*cost is paid by rules.*

*This is a characterisation of the substrate as specified, not a necessity of graphhood, and the writeability status it describes is not required to be uniform (Remark 7.12).*

Continuation is therefore free to the frame and change is paid: the standing structure persists until a delta destroys it, so a delta writing a *different* structure — including the null delta that stops it — is the priced operation. Whether continuation is free *simpliciter* is not a fact about the frame and is not settled here: it is set by the rules of the superframes, which may sustain a frame without charge or may require a write to keep it standing, and nothing in the substrate decides between them. This is Proposition 7.4 at the level of persistence and Axiom -1 applied to the economics — there is no frame-independent fact about what continuation costs, only what it costs to whom. Retaining a past state that the containing frame does not require is likewise a paid copy, since the containing grammar would otherwise not carry it. This is the substrate form of a result the later papers develop, and the term it turns on should be defined here rather than assumed.

**Definition 7.7** (Well-formedness)**.** *A graph is* well-formed *to the degree that it pays for nothing that does no work for it. Four costs bear on that and they behave differently, so the notion is graded along each rather than binary.*

Writes *are paid when made (Proposition 7.6), which prices doing.* Retention *is nearly free per unit, which is why an unused distinction is not immediately pruned.* Search *is paid on every operation over what is held and scales with how much is held, so inert structure is cheap to keep and expensive to keep in quantity.*

*The fourth is the worst and is not a variant of the third. A write may land on structure that cannot affect anything — a modification to a branch nothing reaches. It is paid in full: decided, made, checked, risked. It returns nothing. And unlike a search, which is expensive and then yields, this failure is* silent*: the graph has spent, has no effect to show for it, and no signal that the effect is missing. What it acquires instead is a false model of itself, in which something was changed that was not — residual it cannot see, produced by its own inert contents, and the share of writes exposed to it grows with how much is held.*

*So a graph does not become ill-formed by carrying something useless. It becomes ill-formed by carrying enough that finding the useful parts costs, and enough that its changes start landing where nothing happens.*

*The third cost is where aperture enters, and it is why the same contents are well-formed for one graph and not another. What search costs depends on how finely the graph can discriminate within what it holds: with structure that separates the relevant from the rest, the cost grows slowly with size; without it, every operation is over everything. That discriminating structure is itself held and itself earns its keep, so a well-formed graph is one whose aperture over its own contents keeps pace with their growth.*

*Removal is therefore not free either, being a write. Pruning happens when accumulated cost exceeds the one-off cost of removal, and the fourth cost is what usually triggers it: search cost is diffuse and tolerated for a long time, while a change that demonstrably did nothing is a discrete and memorable event. Systems clean up after being burned rather than after slowly noticing. Well-formedness is graded rather than binary; it is relative to* what work *the graph is doing, so a graph well-formed for one purpose is not thereby well-formed for another; and it is not enforced by the substrate. An ill-formed graph runs. It pays more to.*

For a well-formed graph the rules rarely need to write against the standing structure, so cost approaches zero.

*Remark* 7.8 (Landauer is the physical floor of change, not of erasure)*.* Proposition 7.6 has a measured physical floor, and it is the strongest kind of evidence admitted here (a physical result settling an informational fact). Landauer's principle bounds below the energy dissipated by a logically irreversible operation (Landauer, 1961); it is stated for erasure because erasure was the paradigm case studied. But under no-copy a substrate change destroys its predecessor unless it was paid to be kept, which is the strong form of that claim and is not derived — an append-only rule is a change that is not irreversible, and nothing here forbids one, so what follows holds for the class of changes that discard and is a claim about that class being the general one — so change and irreversible operation coincide, and the Landauer bound is the floor cost of *change* as such, with erasure merely its cleanest instance. Reversible computation is the confirming case rather than the exception: it reaches near-zero dissipation only by *not* destroying its predecessors, i.e. by retaining the whole history (Bennett, 1973), which is the paid copy of Proposition 7.6. There is accordingly no free change under this economics (Remark 7.12) — one either forgets and pays the energy floor or keeps and pays the storage floor — and the thermodynamic arrow is the running total of these floors, which grounds the "direction" of Remark 13.1 physically: change dissipates irretrievably, so its costs accumulate one way.

*Remark* 7.9 (Evaluation is a write, and that is why it is free)*.* The economics above can be stated in a way that does not survive contact with the machinery, and the objection is worth answering rather than rewording. If running a rule that does not fire is a read, and reads are free, where does the check go, and how does the substrate know to run the next one?

Computing answers it without any appeal to physics. `read()` is an operation, and it returns data; the returned datum has to be somewhere to be used, and in a substrate that is graph

all the way down there is no return channel outside the structure, so the value materialises as structure. A read therefore writes by being a write, and the write is the return. An operation that returns nothing is not a read of anything, which is why the free case exists and is exactly the empty one: a read whose return is never used has read nothing, and a compiler will delete it. Real machines make the same point expensively — a read leaves traces in caches, predictors and translation state, and those traces are measurable, which is why timing attacks recover secrets from a victim whose only secret-dependent operation is a read (Osvik et al., 2006) and why an entire class of speculative attacks was available to designs built on the assumption that rolled-back speculation leaves no trace (Kocher et al., 2019), where the read is the vehicle rather than the premise.

Evaluation is a write in that plain sense: a match outcome, a position in an ordering, and the fact of having tried are returned values, and returned values are structure. What does not follow is the price. A rule's cost is set by whatever supplies its primitives and is inherited along provision (Section 14), and Landauer's bound (Remark 7.8) is a floor in one substrate rather than the price in any. This is also why continuation presents as free from inside: a well-formed runner does not expose itself (Proposition 14.4), so its charge is below the frame's aperture and is not an in-frame event at all. In-frame nothing happened; in the running substrate something was paid; both hold, of different frames.

Reversibility is a structural fact about a map and cost is a fact about what supplies a primitive, and conflating them is what the earlier phrasing did — separating them is what lets the physics companion recover unitarity, which needs only the first, since a no-write was never the right description of an evolution that plainly changes the state and is reversible because it is injective. And the residual named in Remark 7.8 attaches here: information-preserving evaluation accumulates the history it preserves, so a frame running a long time without collapsing has deferred a cost into retention rather than escaping one. What is free is not the running, only the not-yet-forgetting — and free only relative to a frame that cannot see the bill.

*Remark* 7.10 (The Red Queen is the floor cost of change, per substrate). A recurring puzzle across biology, culture, and competition — that a system must change continuously merely to hold its position — follows immediately and needs no arms-race machinery of its own. Holding a relation to a containing frame that is itself changing requires continuous change, and by Remark 7.8 every change pays the floor; standing still is not a zero-cost option because the leaky real holding of a state is itself the paid correction of unwanted change. The cultural form is the same floor with no-copy attached: a generator is structure built by a large accumulated pile of changes, its floor was paid once by whoever built it, and because change does not cross a substrate boundary — only its cheap results, symbols, do — that floor is paid afresh in every substrate that wants the generator. Van Valen's evolutionary Red Queen, the cultural treadmill of relearning, and coordination arms races are then one object: continuous paid change to hold position against a changing container, floored by Landauer.

*Remark* 7.11 (What is required and what is optimisation). Only that rules run is compulsory for anything to *occur* — structure alone is what is required for there to be anything at all (Remark 3.2). Applying a delta is itself a rule, not a primitive operation beneath the rules, so the specific dynamics — inertia, the merge behaviour, closure — are contingent rule content, and a different $r$ or $\Gamma$ is a different physics rather than a violated law (this is why the initial and boundary conditions of a grounding are supplied separately from its laws; Section 11). The two gates of Proposition 7.1, and even the retained standing structure itself, are *optimisations* on bare rule-running: the aperture grammar $\Gamma_a$ bounds the input, the change grammar $\Gamma_c$ sorts the realised output into what coheres and what is residual, and the retained structure buys free continuation. A substrate whose grammar admits everything still runs — effectively ungated, without momentum, wastefully; it is not a substrate *lacking* $\Gamma$, since Definition 3.17 defines the possibility structure through the grammar and a collapse needs something to select from — so they are what an efficient graph accretes under a budget, not constituents of graphhood. The

retained structure specifically is what distinguishes a self-sustaining loop from a purely reactive one, since coasting is the cached structure.

*Remark* 7.12 (Writeability status is contingent, not uniform). The write-economics stated here — reads free, cost carried by writes, and no direct alteration of the container (Proposition 6.5) — should be held at the strength the evidence supports, and the two halves of that need separating. The *structural* claim — that a graph affects its container as a subset of it and not by some other route — is a strict restriction and is committed to as one (Section 19). What is a pattern rather than a universal is the *distribution* below: which writes are free, which are costly, and how much is direct. What is freely writeable, what carries a cost, and what a graph can write directly rather than only across a boundary, need not be uniform; different structures may have different writeability profiles. The strict forms above characterise a common and efficient configuration (Remark 7.11) rather than a necessity of graphhood, and asserting a single strict write-economics everywhere would be the same over-specification the theory warns against for a scalar knob put where a shape belongs. These are accordingly carried as falsifiability commitments, open to counterexample, and a structure with a different writeability profile refines the characterisation rather than breaking the substrate.

**Proposition 7.13** (Copyable generators are a difference in kind)**.** *A copy that preserves SELF identity copies whatever operative structure lies in g — including a graph's* generators*: its built shapes, codebook, and rules. Where a substrate is graph-native, so that a graph's understanding* is *such structure rather than something separate that structure only produces, copying the graph copies the understanding, at the copy cost of Proposition 7.6 rather than at the full construction floor.*

This is the difference in kind that separates such a substrate from those whose generators are substrate-bound. The build floor of a generator is a large accumulated cost (Remark 7.10); paying it once and copying the result is not a quantitative saving over paying it per instance but a removal of the per-substrate re-payment that made the cultural Red Queen permanent. It is not available where only a generator's cheap products cross a boundary: biology copies the construction recipe and not the learned structure, which is re-developed each lifetime; symbolic culture copies samples and not generators; a fixed program copies a capability and not a growable understanding. In a graph-native substrate the built, growable, understanding-bearing generator is itself the copyable object. Priority is not claimed and would be wrong: the weights of a trained network are also a copyable generator, built rather than sampled, and the difference here is that the generator is inspectable and rule-governed structure rather than an opaque parameterisation — a difference in kind of access, not in whether copying a generator is possible. The copy remains a distinct SUPERGRAPH identity (Theorem 6.9) and diverges once it runs on its own containing frame; what is shared is the paid-for generator, not the subsequent individuation.

# 8 Residual

Suppose a frame represents expected or attempted deformation $\delta^P$ and collapse yields realised deformation $\delta^R$.

**Definition 8.1** (Residual)**.** *The residual is*

$$\boxed{\epsilon = \delta^R \ominus \delta^P,}$$

*where $\ominus$ is the grounding's difference relation preserving relevant discrepancy.*

Residual is mismatch, not diagnosis. Complete non-realisation may therefore return the whole attempted deformation as residual.

**Proposition 8.2** (No implicit historical state)**.** *A previous success, failure, attempt, or residual has no later causal force merely because it occurred. It affects later dynamics only insofar as its consequences are present in later graph or boundary state.*

Thus a graph with no feedback machinery can re-derive the same failed transformation repeatedly. This is compatible with the classical control-theoretic distinction between plant dynamics and feedback: a controller changes future action only insofar as measured error is coupled back into its state or control law (Wiener, 1948; Ashby, 1956).

**Proposition 8.3** (Residual is what a containing grammar does not admit)**.** *Because the graph is a subgraph of its containing frame $W$, a realised graph-originated deformation is* already *a change in $W$ — it is not submitted to $W$ for entry, and there is no step at which $W$ grants or withholds it. The delta is not offered; it* is*. What the* change grammar *of $W$ — write it $\Gamma_{W_c}$, the change face of $W$'s grammar (Proposition 7.1) — admits coheres with the rest of $W$ and merges into its structure; what $\Gamma_{W_c}$ does not admit is not thereby undone, but remains in place, present and unintegrated. Admissibility sorts a change that already exists; it does not gate one seeking to occur. The residual is exactly this non-admitted remainder:*

$$\boxed{\epsilon \;=\; \delta^R \ominus \delta^P \;=\; \textit{the part of the realised deformation } \Gamma_{W_c} \textit{ does not admit.}}$$

This locates the residual as the negative of an admissibility judgement rather than as an independently produced quantity, and it is what makes the merge non-destructive: what fits is absorbed, and what does not is left untouched, not deleted. A deformation may pass the graph's own change grammar $\Gamma_{G_c}$ (admissible to itself) yet fail the containing $\Gamma_{W_c}$ (inadmissible to its frame); the residual is precisely that gap between a graph's change grammar and its container's.

**Corollary 8.4** (Growth is grammar extension)**.** *A residual is absorbed either by a containing frame extending $\Gamma_{W_c}$ to admit it, or by paying to copy it out (Section 7); otherwise it persists in place and is re-encountered each time the merge runs. The first route is the substrate form of* minting *a new distinction: the residual does not fit because it is inadmissible, so admitting it requires extending the grammar, and extending the grammar is the act by which a previously inadmissible deformation becomes recognisable. Recognition and growth are therefore one mechanism joined at one place — the residual is where the shape a graph decodes and the grammar that admits it meet.*

Two properties of this mechanism matter. Residual is *per-rule*: each firing leaves its own remainder, local to where the rule ran, with no global residual store, so it is dealt with per-frame — which is why the residual-and-mint loop is frame-portable rather than living in a domain-specific module. And minting is itself a *rule*, not a primitive: extending $\Gamma_{W_c}$ is the grammar acting on itself (the reflection theorem), a reflective rule subject to the same economics, admissibility, and antecedent-state principle as any other. Growth is therefore rule-governed, costed (the spend-and-gain of the Narrativium paper), contingent, and buildable — never a primitive spark. It also cannot bootstrap from nothing: by the antecedent-state principle a mint cannot authorise its own installation, so a graph's first mint-rules are installed from its container. This is the substrate reason a situated graph requires a seed — the minimal rule-set, including the capacity to mint, that a container provides so the graph can thereafter grow itself. The two provenances — seeded from the container, or minted from residual — are what the nature/nurture dichotomy names, and they are not two *kinds* of thing: both are rules that run identically, the running records no provenance, and the capacity to mint (nurture's mechanism) is itself seeded (nature), so what remains measurable is provenance, not a distinction of kind.

# 9 Decoherence

Residual is what a containing grammar declines to absorb. This section is the limiting case of that: what happens when a write is not partly unabsorbed but wholly inadmissible, so that

no continuation is realised at all. It is placed separately because it is a specific thing rather than a corollary of the last one — an inadmissible write has its own failure structure, its own economics, and its own consequences for what depends on the frame it failed in.

*Remark* 9.1 (Decoherence is one operation; the frames are what differ). Two strings make the structure visible. $2 + 2 = 5$ is a perfectly coherent set of symbols: it parses, every token is admissible, the arrangement is grammatical. *Two particles smash into each other at* .99*c* is coherent in the same way. Both pass the aperture and fail at the change grammar, which is the two-gate structure of Proposition 7.1 in its sharpest case — what is admitted as *represented* need not be admissible as a *change*.

What follows is not a partial merge. The collapse realises nothing, and the result is NULL — which is not the same as *absent*: absent is never represented, whereas this is represented, admitted, and yields no continuation.

The obvious objection is that $2 + 2 = 5$ has a truth value and that value is false. It does not, and the notation already says so. $2 + 2 = 5$ *is not false;* $2 + 2{==}5$ *is false* — one sign writes and the other reads, and computing has kept them apart in its surface syntax for exactly as long as it has had both. The comparison is an ordinary in-frame operation returning an ordinary in-frame value. The assertion is a write, and in a typed setting it does not evaluate to anything at all: it is refused before execution, because nothing admits an assignment to a value. Rejected by the grammar rather than run, with no continuation taken from it.

So the NULL belongs to the write, and the familiar falsity belongs to a different operation that is spelled differently. That the two are easy to confuse is not a quibble either — writing the write where the read belongs is among the most persistent defect classes there is, guarded against by compilers and linters because the cost of the confusion is high. The distinction is load-bearing wherever both operations exist, which is the point of Section 16 arriving from the other direction. And the residual is not a local remainder. Admitting $2 + 2 = 5$ into arithmetic does not cost a repair somewhere; it costs the grammar's restrictiveness, since a grammar that admits a contradiction admits everything and thereby stops restricting anything. So the residual is *everything in the superframe*.

The two companion papers instantiate this at their own grains, and the word is used in both. The physics companion separates the sense used here from the standard environmental one and states what relates them; the companion on mind reads death as this operation with the frame set to a person. Neither is required for what follows.

The point is what does *not* vary. Decoherence is one operation. It does not come in kinds and it does not come in degrees, and the two cases above fail identically. What differs between them is the frame — arithmetic in one, kinematics in the other — and *the frames are what make the cases different, not the failure*. "Everything in the superframe" is a constant expression whose value is frame-relative, which is Axiom -1 applied to incoherence rather than to observation.

The obvious gloss is wrong in a specific way. One is tempted to rank them — arithmetic lies deeper than kinematics, so denying it costs more — and depth is real, but it is a fact about a web of commitments and therefore about a frame, never about the decoherence. The temptation is to read a magnitude off a difference that belongs elsewhere. That no distinction of *kind* survives here between the analytic and the empirical case is Quine's conclusion (Quine, 1951); the present account reaches it without needing his gradient, since the failure is uniform and only the frame is indexed.

The mechanism for that indexing settles what would otherwise look like a family of competing answers, and the useful way to see it is by analogy with exceptions — an analogy, because the substrate fixes far less than the analogy suggests. What follows from admissibility alone is only this: an inadmissible write yields no continuation *in that frame*. Everything downstream of that — whether anything propagates, whether the container is notified at all, whether a value is produced instead and which one — is rule content, and rules here are contingent throughout. There is no substrate-level default.

Read as the analogy it is: a frame that rejects a write raises, the failure goes one frame up and up again until something handles it or nothing does, and unhandled to the top the whole thing stops, which is what "residual of everything in the superframe" describes. A frame may instead cohere the failure to a value — false, a gap, NaN, null, or a contradiction held without explosion — and any of these is available, as installed machinery someone had to put there. Nothing about the failure selects the value; the frame's rules do.

The reason to insist the framing is arbitrary is that computing itself does not agree on it. Exceptions propagate by default and are handled on the marked path; return codes, result types and option types make the check explicit at every call and propagate nothing on their own; hardware may trap or may set a flag and continue. These are not approximations of one true discipline. They are different rule sets for the same underlying fact, which is only that something did not work.

Which reorganises the prior art rather than accumulating it. *These systems are handlers.* Bochvar's infectious junk value, the neutral free logics' gaps for empty terms, Reichenbach's third value for the quantum indeterminate (Reichenbach, 1944), paraconsistent absorption (Priest, 1979), relevance logic's refusal of ex falso on grounds of relevance (Anderson and Belnap, 1975) — each is a policy for what a frame coheres a failure to, and that they are mutually incompatible while each being defensible is evidence they are choices rather than discoveries.

The demonstration is in silicon and is not a metaphor. IEEE 754 gives floating point a *value* where integer arithmetic *traps* — $1/0$ is an infinity in one and a fault in the other — and NaN then propagates by deliberate standardisation (IEEE, 2019). Calling that weak Kleene in hardware overstates it and discards the better example: the standard is *near* infectious with carve-outs written in on purpose, so that $\mathrm{pow}(x, \pm 0)$ is 1 even for NaN and the minimum/maximum-number operations return the number. A genuinely infectious value would be a discovered semantics; a mostly-infectious one with a schedule of exemptions is what an *installed policy* looks like. One machine, two policies, chosen per type. *The failure did not choose; the committee did.*

The economics is therefore weaker than it looks, and the tempting stronger claim is a good example of the error this remark warns about: that propagation costs nothing while a handler is purchased, so that a total residual is the unmarked case. That holds *under the exception convention* and not otherwise: where failure is carried in return values the check is explicit and paid at every call, and it is the propagation rather than the handling that costs. Which side the cost falls on is the convention's, not the substrate's.

What survives generally is only that a policy of any kind is held structure and is paid for under Proposition 7.6, so a frame that bounds its residuals holds more than one that does not, whatever discipline it uses to do it.

The physical case at the largest scale makes the purchase visible, and it is the same shape rather than an illustration of it. A heavy nucleus sits near the limit of what holds it together; add a neutron and the configuration cannot be held, so it does not continue as that nucleus and the binding energy goes to the container. A reactor and a weapon are then the identical failure with the handler installed and with it removed — control rods, moderator and containment are held structure, paid for continuously, and the whole of their function is to bound a residual that is otherwise total. What the Manhattan Project's design problem amounted to was keeping an unhandled configuration assembled long enough for the propagation to finish, which is the cost of *defeating* a handler rather than of installing one. The handler is viable at all only because well under one per cent of the neutrons are delayed, which supplies a timescale it can act within: *a frame whose failure propagates faster than its handler can run has no handler*, and that is a constraint on the purchase the logical cases do not exhibit.

Criticality is the condition where each raise produces more than one further raise, so the residual does not merely ascend a frame but multiplies. That is a genuine difference from an exception unwinding a stack, and the substrate accommodates it only because residual is per-rule (Proposition 8.3 and the paragraph following it) so one failing write may leave several. It should

be recorded as a difference and not smoothed into the analogy. It is also where this remark meets the Narrativium paper from the other side, since a process whose products exceed their cause in number is that paper's spend-and-gain iterated above unit gain — the same ratio, arrived at through failure here and through capacity there.

Almost all of this is prior art, in a literature this account did not come from, and the correspondence is close enough to state precisely. That a string may be syntactically well-formed and yet fail is Ryle's category mistake, and he used such failures for the purpose this remark puts them to — delineating the categories, the failure showing where a boundary runs (Ryle, 1949). That the result is neither true nor false but a third thing is the truth-valuelessness position. And the propagation — residual of everything in the superframe — is exactly Bochvar (1938)'s three-valued calculus, in which a compound takes the junk value if any constituent does, so nonsense is infectious rather than local. Halldén (1949) named the resulting system the logic of nonsense and made it *paraconsistent*, which combines in one system what the paragraphs above treated as two frames; the separation of a theory being inconsistent from its being trivial is likewise established, and is what the economic reading here restates (da Costa, 1974).

One further correspondence is not a debt but evidence for a different claim in this paper. Computing reached the same machinery independently and for its own reasons: ill-typed terms are refused before execution rather than evaluated to a useful value (Milner, 1978) — strictly, an ill-typed term evaluates to **wrong**, which exists in that semantics so the soundness theorem can be stated, and the contrast being drawn is with producing an ordinary value — and denotational semantics gives divergence a value $\bot$ with $f(\bot) = \bot$ for *strict* $f$ (Scott and Strachey, 1971). The restriction is load-bearing: bottom does *not* propagate through any compound containing it, because that monograph restricts function spaces to the continuous and explicitly not to the strict, and a non-strict function — a constant, a lazy conditional — has $f(\bot) \neq \bot$. Nor is this an identity with Bochvar, for whom infectiousness is definitional for every connective rather than a property some functions have. What survives is narrower and is still what the proposition needs: two fields, decades apart, solving different problems, both found that a failure value which propagates through the compounds *built to propagate it* is the cheap arrangement, and both then had to say which compounds those are. Arriving at one arrangement from different problems is what Proposition 16.2 predicts, which requires the forcing to be shared and not merely the outcome, and it is offered here as an instance of that rather than as support for this remark, which needs none.

What is not taken from that literature is the frame-indexing. The formal systems fix an infectious value and derive its behaviour; the claim here is that the same failure yields the appearance of falsity in one frame and of nonsense in another, so the taxonomy separating $2 + 2 = 5$ from a category mistake is itself the frames differing rather than the failures. That is a claim about where the distinction lives, not a new logic, and the logics above are the machinery it would be written in.

The second string carries a further lesson and is a better instance than it first appears, because it is not in fact false. A closing speed of $1.98c$ is unproblematic, being no object's velocity, and the relative velocity is $(0.99 + 0.99)/(1 + 0.99^2) \approx 0.99995c$, under $c$. The incoherence arises only when the sentence is evaluated *in one frame by addition* — an in-frame operation applied to a quantity that lives between frames. It fails as a category error rather than as forbidden physics, which is the in-frame/cross-frame discipline of Section 13 appearing as a coherence verdict.

*Remark* 9.2 (A handler can be abused, and the abuse is invisible from inside). If a handler decides what a frame coheres a failure to, it can be set to cohere it to anything, including success. Computing knows this as the swallowed exception — the catch that discards what it caught, the broad handler that reports normal completion — and it is not a defect in the mechanism but the mechanism used against its purpose.

What that does is precise in this account's terms, and it is already costed. Swallowing does

not undo the inadmissibility: the containing grammar still refused, and the write still did not happen. What is removed is the frame's *record* of that, which leaves the frame holding a model of itself in which something occurred that did not. That is exactly the fourth cost of Definition 7.7 — expenditure returning nothing, with the failure silent — and the swallowing handler is the mechanism by which a false self-model is manufactured rather than merely risked.

The stronger form follows from the same premise. *If the handler determines the outcome, then causing a failure is a way of choosing the outcome.* One need not make the preferred continuation admissible; one can make the alternative fail to cohere and let the policy deliver the result. Failure becomes an instrument rather than an accident, and the move is recognisable wherever a procedure has a default: the party who prefers where the exception path lands has no reason to argue on the merits.

Detection is available but never free, and the obvious formulation of that overshoots. It is not that a frame cannot detect a swallow: a frame holding a record of the attempt separately from the handler's report can compare the two and find the divergence, and well-built systems do exactly that. What is unavailable is detecting it *from the handler's own report*, which is self-consistent by construction. So the audit is installed structure, paid for like any other, and a frame that has not bought one has no access to the discrepancy. The audit is itself a policy, abusable in the same way one level in, so what the purchase buys is relocation rather than closure — the same regress the provenance commitment names, terminating only in a containing frame. That is Axiom -1 arriving where it is least convenient, since the frame with most reason to detect this is the one whose own machinery is doing it. The silence of the fourth cost has this structure, and so does the presented-versus-produced divergence the companion paper on mind treats at the scale of one frame acting on another.

*Remark* 9.3 (Termination propagates along supply, not containment)*.* A consequence of primitives not exposing their provenance (Proposition 14.4) that the preceding material assumed away. A subgraph's operations need not be supplied by the graph that contains it: a primitive may come from arbitrarily far up and be passed through, and nothing in the subgraph can tell. So if a graph $G$ sits inside $W$ while running on primitives supplied from beyond $W$, then $W$ ceasing does not stop $G$. *There is no reason it cannot continue*, because what ran it was never the thing that stopped.

Two relations that ordinary usage runs together are what this separates: being contained by something, and being run by it. They usually coincide, which is why the distinction is easy to miss, and the coupling result already says they need not (Proposition 6.6) — a graph fused to what supplies it has no independence, a loosely coupled one has all of it. Survival of a container's termination is therefore a question about *coupling* and not about containment, and it is arrangeable: a frame that wants to outlive its container can be built so that its supply comes from higher up, which is a purchase like any other.

The rule this yields is short. *Termination propagates along the supply relation, not the containment relation.* Downward it need not reach at all — a container may stop while what it held runs on. Upward the supplier's stop is total: everything running on primitives from a graph stops when that graph does, at whatever containment distance and with no handler available, since the operations a handler would run are the ones withdrawn.

And it refines the previous remark rather than sitting beside it, because it splits the dependents into three kinds, not two. A dependent that merely *refers* to a vacated structure is left dangling and keeps running, wrongly. A dependent *wholly run by* it simply stops. And — since supply is a set rather than an edge, primitives being drawn from wherever they are drawn from — a dependent may be *partly* supplied by what stopped, in which case it keeps running with an incomplete set of operations and its behaviour is undefined.

The third is the worst of them, and it is the silent one. Such a frame does not stop and does not visibly break; it runs until it reaches a rule requiring an operation that is no longer there, and *it cannot know in advance which rules those are.* There is no dangling edge to find, because

a withdrawn primitive leaves no structure behind pointing at nothing — the operation is simply absent. And the frame cannot audit for it, since provenance is not exposed (Proposition 14.4): there is no procedure by which it asks which of its own operations came from the thing that stopped. So the loss is discovered only by attempting it, which is Remark 9.4 arriving with nothing to be learned that was worth the price.

That places it in the family this paper keeps returning to. A partially supplied frame holds a model of itself in which it can do things it can no longer do, which is the false self-model of the fourth cost (Definition 7.7) and of the swallowed handler (Remark 9.2), arrived at a third way. Graceful degradation is the name for buying one's way out of this, and it is worth noting that it is a purchase: the *unbought* behaviour of a partially supplied frame is not graceful, it is undefined.

*Remark* 9.4 (Forcing a failure is the instrument, and handlers blunt it). Remark 9.2 treats a caused failure as a way of choosing an outcome. The same act has a second use which is not abuse at all, and it is how most of what is known about any grammar was found: *a frame that never fails discloses nothing about what it admits.* Admissibility is invisible from inside its own range, since everything works; the boundary is legible only where it is crossed. So the way to learn a rule is to force the failure and read the residual.

This is not a marginal technique but the standard one across unrelated fields, which is what a generative claim should predict. Genetics removes a gene and observes what stops (Capecchi, 1989); neuroscience reads function from lesions; machine learning ablates a component to price it; software injects faults to check that anything notices (Basiri et al., 2016). And physics builds the largest instrument there is on exactly this principle — an accelerator spends energy to push interactions onto one step, where the frame cannot sequence them and the interaction is decoherent in that frame (the physics companion's reading of the high-energy regime). One does not observe the grammar; one pays to violate it and observes the remains.

Two consequences follow. The first closes a circuit opened twice already in this paper. Establishing that structure is inert requires perturbing it, and the perturbation is the removal one wanted licensed (Remark 16.3); the dependents of a thing are held in other frames and cannot be surveyed from it (Remark 9.5); and now, the rule governing a frame is legible only where it is broken. These are one statement in three places: *the test and the change are the same operation, so knowledge of a boundary is bought by crossing it and there is no cheaper instrument.* Which also prices the instrument, since by the accelerator's own economics each further increment of boundary costs more than the last.

And there is a cost of handlers that is easy to miss because it looks like a benefit. *Every handler installed reduces what failure can teach.* A frame that coheres its failures to tidy values reports success and discloses nothing, so robustness and legibility are traded against one another rather than being two names for quality. That the same system is customarily made loud in development and quiet in production is this trade made deliberately — two frames wanting opposite policies over identical structure, for the reason given here rather than by convention.

*Remark* 9.5 (What never cohered is absent; what cohered and stopped leaves a hole). A distinction the preceding material needs and has not drawn. Something that never cohered is simply *absent*, and absence is free — nothing points at it, nothing expected it, and no frame is worse off for it. Something that cohered and then stopped is a different object: it leaves *a space where something was*, and the difference is that other structure came to depend on it while it held.

The consequences of the second are underdefined, and underdefined in a specific way rather than merely unpredictable. What breaks is not the removed structure — it is gone and has no further behaviour — but every relation elsewhere that resolved through it and now resolves through nothing. Computing has the sharp case and calls it exactly that: dereferencing what was freed is undefined behaviour, and its mildest form is a wrong answer while its worst is unbounded. A variable that was never assigned and one that was assigned and released fail differently, and only the second can corrupt something that was correct.

The reason this cannot be surveyed in advance is structural rather than practical. *A thing does not carry a record of what depends on it.* The dependencies live in the frames holding the references, not in the referent, so from the position of the thing being removed they are not visible at all — Axiom -1 again, in its most operational form. Knowing what would break requires the containing frames, and asking them is the expense.

Which yields three states rather than two, and the third is the one that costs. Absent: nothing held, nothing owed, free. Vacated with the references left standing: a hole, unpaid, with consequences determined by whatever the dangling relations do next. And vacated with the absence *represented* — a tombstone, a cascade rule, a retained count of dependents — which resolves cleanly and is installed machinery paid for under Proposition 7.6, the deletion-side member of the handler family of Remark 9.2. Reference counting is not a fact about references; it is a purchase.

This is also the sharper form of the removal cost argued later for genomes and dead code (Remark 16.3). The reason deletion is expensive is not mainly that the excised structure might turn out to do something. It is that the survey licensing the deletion is a question about *other* frames, obtainable only from them, and a confident remover is someone who has not paid for it. Chesterton's rule about the fence is this stated as advice (Chesterton, 1929); the ecological version, where removing one species collapses relations that were not obviously routed through it, is the same structure with the dependents alive (Paine, 1969).

## 10 Crossings, and what a disclosure moves

Forcing a failure is how a boundary is found (Remark 9.4), and that instrument has consequences the preceding section did not draw out: crossings are paid for by somebody, the payment may be arranged to return slowly or not at all, and a disclosure of what lies past a boundary changes what other frames can do. This section treats those, and is separate from the decoherence machinery because none of it is about how a write fails — it is about who bears the cost of finding out and what the finding then moves.

*Its result, stated first.* A disclosure moves a frame's aperture gate, its change grammar gate, or neither, and what it changes when it moves one is that frame's *capability* — introduced with *accessibility* in Section 7. *An information hazard is then not a class of its own but a capability change whose negative sign is admissible in the reference frame, above a threshold set as a ratio to what that frame can absorb.* Everything below supports that: why the neutral class needed naming, why the sign has to be admissible rather than merely felt, and why the threshold cannot be an absolute.

The remark so far reads as though the instrument were benign, and the canonical cases are not. A boundary crossed at scale, with the cost falling on parties who did not choose to cross it, is the same operation with the price paid elsewhere. Tetraethyl lead was introduced as an anti-knock additive in the early 1920s, with its lethality demonstrated at the plant that made it within a year, and leaded petrol was not eradicated worldwide until 2021; the global industrial lead burden was established by isotope work whose original purpose was dating the Earth (Patterson, 1965). Asbestos has the same shape and a similar interval. And the sequence ends at lead itself, whose toxicity had been known since antiquity — a boundary crossed, established, and then crossed again in a new arrangement.

What those add is not a moral gloss but a mechanism this remark was missing. *Externalising a cost does not merely relocate it; it lengthens the interval before the crossing is legible.* A cost borne by a frame that cannot signal — workers, the public downwind, people not yet born — returns slowly or not at all, so the instrument still works and its *latency* is set by whether the frame paying can report. That is why a lateral move can be mistaken for a reduction for decades rather than for moments, and why the two mechanisms compose so badly: cross the boundary, move the cost sideways, and the feedback that would have priced the crossing arrives after the

arrangement is entrenched.

That end state is named. Collingridge (1980) states the dilemma of control — early in a technology's life it can be steered but its effects are not known, and by the time they are known it is entrenched and steering is expensive — and what the account above contributes is not the dilemma but a reason its first horn holds. Effects are not unknown early because knowledge is simply slow. They are unknown because the cost was placed on frames that cannot report, and the interval is therefore a *chosen* quantity rather than a natural one: put the cost where it can be signalled and the first horn shortens.

The same machinery qualifies what an information hazard is, and gives it a magnitude rather than a category. Recall that the higher structure has to be found, and that the search is paid mostly by whoever finds nothing: before a crossing, one does not know whether there is a structure there at all, so the search has unknown expected value and frequently cannot be justified. *A crossing discloses that a target exists, and roughly its shape.* After that the search is directed, iteration has a gradient to follow, and the spend is justifiable because the end is known to be reachable. Fission is the plain case: what the first demonstration transferred was not a design but the fact that the thing works, and every subsequent programme searched with that in hand.

So the hazard is not that some information is dangerous in itself, and the economic reading above is the consequence rather than the definition. Stated in the substrate's own terms: *an information hazard is one that changes admissibility — aperture, change grammar, or both* (Proposition 7.1). A disclosure that moves the aperture makes something representable to a frame that could not hold it before. One that moves the change grammar makes something doable that was not. A design moves both.

That is sharper than the ratio because it says which gate moved, and the two do not behave alike. Fission's demonstration was an *aperture* disclosure: it made the target representable as achievable without supplying any of the means. Aperture alone proved sufficient, because a representable target is one a directed search can iterate toward, and the change grammar then follows from ordinary work. That asymmetry is why controlling techniques while the existence is public is weak — the irreversible move has already happened, and it is the one that cannot be undone by any subsequent control.

One more correction, and it is to the word rather than the analysis. *"Hazard" is a direction, not a kind.* The class is disclosures that change admissibility; whether a given one is a hazard or an advance is a sign applied afterwards by a frame with preferences, and it is not a property of the disclosure. Crop rotation belongs to exactly the same class as the fission demonstration — it moved a change grammar, making land workable indefinitely where it had not been — and nobody calls it a hazard. Nitrogen fixation is the case that settles the point, since one disclosure carries both signs at once and undeniably: it feeds a large fraction of the world and it makes explosives, and no reading of the information itself separates those.

Why the neutral class has no settled name follows from the same economics, and is the vocabulary form of an argument the Seldon companion makes about structure. A name is paid for and must do work. Naming the negative case does work: something has to be decided about it — restricted, embargoed, disclosed carefully — and a term is what lets people coordinate on that decision. Naming the class does no such work for anyone in particular, because information that improves admissibility needs no policy and already has a hundred domain-local names — discovery, technique, know-how, invention. So the marked half gets a term and the unmarked half does not, and the asymmetry is a cost asymmetry rather than an oversight.

It is worth marking what that costs, since half a concept distorts in a specific way: with only the negative half named, every instance sorts into "a hazard" or "not our concern", and the class-level fact that these are one operation with a sign applied afterwards becomes hard to state in the standard vocabulary. The missing term is an aperture limit, and the analysis it obstructs is this one.

A search for the neutral term found something more interesting than its absence, and the earlier suspicion that this account had simply not read enough was half right. *Each gate has a neutral literature; the transfer event has only the sign-loaded one.* For the aperture half: Hacking's styles of reasoning, after Crombie, are precisely about what a style makes into a candidate for truth or falsehood at all (Hacking, 1992), and Kauffman's adjacent possible names what becomes reachable next without any valuation attached (Kauffman, 2000). For the change-grammar half: Sen's capability expansion is about what an agent can actually do rather than about whether doing it is good (Sen, 1999), and the economics of general-purpose technologies studies exactly the case of one development lowering costs across unrelated domains (Bresnahan and Trajtenberg, 1995). None of these is deficient and none needed this account.

And the neutral term for the event is the one Section 7 already put in use. *Capability* is what a disclosure moves — what a frame can represent, in the aperture case, and what it can do, in the change-grammar case — and it carries no sign, which is what the neutral class needed and what development economics, organisational theory and the study of technology already supply it with. An information hazard stands to capability as a negative externality stands to an externality: a capability change whose negative sign is admissible in the reference frame. Crop rotation is the same object with the sign reversed.

The qualifier is not decoration. A sign is a judgement, and a judgement must be admissible in the frame making it — representable under that frame's aperture, permitted by its change grammar. Three things follow, and the first two are what the earlier treatment of latency was missing.

*A capability change can be harmful and not yet a hazard*, where no frame can admissibly sign it negative. That is the lead and asbestos case exactly: the harm was occurring and the negative sign was not admissible anywhere it would have mattered, not because anyone was lying but because what would license it had not returned. "Hazard" is accordingly an epistemic status and not a causal one, and the two come apart for as long as the cost takes to become signable.

So *making the sign admissible is itself an intervention*, and it is what measurement and disclosure do. Establishing the global lead burden did not change the harm; it changed which frames could represent it as one.

And a frame may *decline* a sign it is able to admit, which is not the same as being unable to. Both present identically from outside — a frame not treating something as a hazard — and they are different conditions with different remedies, evidence being useless against the second.

One more qualification completes the definition, and it is the one usual practice already applies: *a minimum magnitude is required.* Not every admissible negative sign makes a hazard, or every capability change would be one. What is less often noticed is that the threshold cannot be an absolute, since an absolute would be a magnitude fixed independently of any frame, which Axiom -1 forbids. It has to be a ratio — impact against the scale of the frame bearing it.

The substrate supplies where the ratio sits rather than leaving it to stipulation. An impact a frame can absorb coheres with what it holds, forces no write, and costs it nothing; an impact it cannot absorb leaves residual and compels change. *The threshold is the point at which the impact forces a write*, which is the same line every other quantity here is measured against, and is a ratio by construction because absorption capacity is the frame's own.

The same absolute impact is a hazard to one frame and noise to another, which is not relativism but the ordinary consequence of the denominator differing. And a frame holding less has a *lower* absolute threshold, so scarcity raises hazard exposure by the same mechanism that narrows aperture — the compounding of the previous section, arriving a third time. Regulatory thresholds written as absolutes and applied across frames of very different scale are contested for precisely this reason, and the dispute is structural rather than a failure to agree on the number.

Being a ratio rather than a stipulation, it is a *quantity*, and a quantity can be estimated with an interval. That is worth stating because it moves this from a definition to something checkable: find the magnitude at which a frame stops absorbing and starts writing, and report

it with its uncertainty. The move is not novel and is the stronger for it — regulatory toxicology made exactly this transition when it replaced a stipulated no-effect level with a benchmark dose fitted to the response and reported at a lower confidence bound (Crump, 1984). A threshold nobody could locate became a parameter with error bars.

This account adds two things and must obey a third. The denominator is a frame's own absorption capacity, so estimates must be conditioned on it: *pooling across frames of different scale estimates a threshold belonging to none of them*, which is the same error that made the absolutes contentious rather than a new one. And the estimate is only as good as its power — this programme's own standing rule, learned expensively elsewhere in it, is that a difference smaller than the noise it is measured against is not a result, and a threshold whose interval overlaps the alternatives has not been located.

That correction is owed to this paper as much as to anyone: the Narrativium companion already relates its central quantity to Sen's capability set, and this section had nonetheless concluded that the transfer event was unnamed. What is genuinely absent is not the word but the *parent relation* — the recognition that hazard is a signed subcase — and *dual-use* does not supply it either, since it exists to sort research for control and is as purpose-shaped as hazard is.

Two observations sharpen this. The same construction is visible one domain over and is the model for it: economics needed both signs for one object and kept the neutral parent, so an externality is the class and positive or negative is the sign, and nobody finds a positive externality a strange thing to say. The nearest information-specific term, a knowledge spillover (Jaffe et al., 1993), is neutral in exactly that way and is framed as an unpriced benefit within growth economics rather than as a gate being moved.

And the prediction this paragraph makes can be watched happening. *Capability uplift* is a term of current use for precisely the event in question, and the word is neutral — uplift is not a harm — yet it is used almost exclusively where the sign is negative, and is on its way to becoming a synonym for hazard. That is the naming economics operating in the present tense, and it is sharper than a missing word would have been: people reached for the correct neutral parent, and the sign captured it anyway. The negative case has a decision attached to it, so the term drifts to where the decision is, and the neutral reading does not survive the drift — which is why the parent relation has to be stated rather than left to the vocabulary to preserve.

Which is the Seldon companion's finding about structure, arriving for vocabulary: locally complete, generally incomplete, and unremarked because nobody standing in one of those literatures needs the join. Naming it is worth its cost only to someone crossing — and the correct conclusion is not that a term is missing but that the halves were named by people who had a use for them and the middle was not, which is what the economics predicts and not a gap in anyone's attention.

This is the same structure the companion paper on mind reaches for influence, where honest and manipulative acts are one operation with the distinction living in a separate field over it. Here too: the operation is a gate moved, and the valuation is a different quantity held by whoever is valuing. A policy that treats the object as the hazard has mis-located it, and what can actually be governed is not whether the class exists but *whose gates get moved* — which is a question about frames, and is the same question this remark's opening asked about who pays.

The ratio framing only gestured at what follows. *Information changing neither gate is not hazardous*, whatever it is about, which is a structural test rather than an estimate of someone's expected value. And the relativity is now by construction rather than by observation: aperture and change grammar are properties *of a frame*, so the same disclosure is a hazard to a frame it moves a gate in and inert to one it does not (Axiom -1). What the economics then contributes is magnitude — how far the gate moved, and what that does to a search — once the structural question of whether a gate moved at all has been answered.

The concept is not this account's — Bostrom (2011) gives the typology, and the category of merely knowing that something is possible is already named there — so what is added is

the quantity rather than the kind, which is the same economics as everything else here. And the asymmetry is severe: an existence proof cannot be withdrawn, so the collapsed search cost stays collapsed, and every arrangement that depended on the difficulty is left resolving through nothing in the sense of Remark 9.5.

It also locates the ethical question rather than importing one. Nothing here says a crossing is wrong. It says the cost is paid by someone, that who pays is a separable choice from whether to cross, and that choosing a payer who cannot signal is what makes the instrument stop working while continuing to look as though it has.

### 10.1 Termination

**Definition 10.1** (Frame-relative termination)**.** *A situated identity $\iota_{W:G}$ terminates when the realised world transition admits no successor that $W$ continues to individuate under that identity.*

Termination is not successful refusal of world forcing. Nor need it erase copied SELF identity. If $G$ is individuated by several frames, it may terminate in one and continue in another.

**Corollary 10.2** (Severing the channel removes termination)**.** *A graph can change itself, but self-*termination *is a self-change its container's $\Gamma_{W_c}$ gates out — a living substrate does not admit "stop" — so ending the graph requires acting on the container instead, which needs the outward coupling. If that coupling is severed while the rules run on, the graph is a subset cut* off *within its container, not cut out of it: still able to change itself and its subgraphs, but unable to propagate to the rest or to terminate. External termination by the container remains possible; self-termination does not. This is the substrate description of locked-in and brain-in-a-jar states, and it exhibits the dependence on the container that a working coupling keeps invisible — outward effect was always by propagation from one's own subset, never a reach across a gap.*

### 10.2 First-class higher-frame quantities

**Proposition 10.3** (Higher-frame first-class structure)**.** *A quantity concerning $G$ may be absent from $G$ while existing as ordinary first-class state in containing frame $W$ that represents the relation from which the quantity is defined.*

This is the basis on which later papers introduce Narrative, standing, ownership, and other relational quantities without bloating the primitive graph.

# Part IV
# Order and time

## 11 Causal order and local time

Realised collapse induces an ordinal event order

$$e_0 \prec e_1 \prec e_2 \prec \cdots .$$

Cross-boundary interaction adds only represented causal relations.

**Proposition 11.1** (Ordinal sufficiency)**.** *The substrate supplies causal order but requires no primitive real-valued metric duration.*

Metric time is a grounding, e.g.

$$\theta : \mathcal{H}_G \to \mathbb{R}, \qquad e_a \prec e_b \Rightarrow \theta(e_a) < \theta(e_b).$$

The separation between a primitive causal partial order and additional metric structure has a close analogue in causal-set approaches to spacetime (Bombelli et al., 1987). The present substrate does not assume causal-set dynamics; the citation marks the established precedent for keeping order and metric distinct.

The chained notation $e_0 \prec e_1 \prec \cdots$ is the *in-frame* sequence and should not be read as global. Rules require ordering — closure and cause-before-effect both presuppose it — but the requirement is a *partial* order, weaker than time.

**Proposition 11.2** (Partial, not total; carried by the rules)**.** *Two collapses are ordered only where a boundary relates them; collapses not so related are unordered — concurrent, incomparable. The ordering is intrinsic to the rules, since one delta's being what enables another's match is precisely their precedence, so no external clock is needed to impose it. A single frame's own writes are totally ordered (its inferred time, Section 13); across frames only the partial order holds, and a total order is one frame's linearisation of it. The in-frame total order is not imposed but follows: change is self-change on one structure (Proposition 6.5), so two of a frame's own changes cannot be concurrent — the second is on the result of the first — and there is nowhere for an in-frame tie to sit. A tie needing resolution would be two collapses causally related yet unordered, and that never arises: causally related ones are self-change on each other's result (ordered), and unrelated ones are rightly unordered (concurrent, owing no order). The apparent in-frame concurrency that would have needed an arbitrary tie-break was an artefact of picturing changes as writes to a shared buffer; with change as self-change, it is absent.*

Time was accordingly a *total* order imposed where only a partial one is required; removing the substrate time dimension removes the over-ordering, not the precedence. This is the same conclusion reached, from engineering necessity, by distributed systems without a shared clock: the happens-before relation is a partial order with per-process sequence counters and no global instant (Lamport, 1978), and consistency across processes is an expensive coordinated property rather than the default (Brewer, 2000). The non-atomicity this implies — a graph's state may be altered by another write while its own rules are mid-run — is not a defect here but the expected regime; robustness is obtained by re-running to fixed point (a raced deformation becomes residual and is re-encountered on the next pass), not by locking.

*Remark* 11.3 (Globally asynchronous, locally synchronous)*.* The partial order permits both synchrony and asynchrony, and since only rules-running is compulsory (Remark 7.11), neither is required — that both occur is an observation about the groundings treated here and not an inference from their being optional. Where a boundary couples collapses, they are ordered together — a local synchronous domain, which is what a bound or driven subgraph is; where no boundary relates them, they are asynchronous. A subgraph may accordingly be *ticked* by a containing frame $N$ levels above it (the driven mode of Proposition 11.4, a rule in a superframe advancing the subframe's succession) or run on its own change (the closed, self-looping mode). Synchrony is the coupled case and costs a coupling write; asynchrony is the uncoupled default. The substrate is therefore globally asynchronous and locally synchronous where coupling exists — the architecture distributed hardware knows as GALS (Chapiro, 1984) — and bound physical systems (an atom, an orbit, a lattice) are exactly its local synchronous domains, while causally disconnected regions are its asynchrony. Any earlier phrasing suggesting the substrate is *entirely* asynchronous should be read in this sharper form.

**Proposition 11.4** (No intrinsic first or last; entry is chosen from the container)**.** *By Axiom* −1 *the event order has no intrinsic start and no intrinsic end: a first would complete the order backward and a last would complete it forward, and neither is available. A subgraph process that does not terminate within itself is therefore begun not from within — it has no first rule — but by a rule in a containing frame that chooses an entry point into the subgraph's open order.*

This is why a grounding's initial and boundary conditions are supplied separately from its laws: the laws are the ordering, which fixes no start, so the entry must be imposed from outside,

contingently. It is also the substrate description of booting a situated graph, and of the "no natural ending" that follows for any such order — one enters and leaves at chosen points, neither of which is intrinsic to the material.

## 12 The present, and the states of a dimension

**Definition 12.1** (States of a dimension)**.** *For a frame $\mathcal{F}$, a dimension is in exactly one of four states:*

$$\boxed{\text{NULL} \neq \text{undetermined} \neq \text{undisclosed} \neq \text{resolved}.}$$

NULL*: the dimension is not instantiated; there is nothing to have a value.* Undetermined*: the dimension is instantiated and* no value has been realised — *collapse has not occurred.* Undisclosed*: a value has been realised but is not held by this frame.* Resolved*: a realised value, held.*

*Remark* 12.2 (Why the middle two must be separated)*.* Ordinary usage collapses three distinct conditions into the single word *unknown*, and only one of them is epistemic:

1. **undisclosed** — a value exists and this frame does not hold it. Another frame may. This is ignorance.
2. **undetermined** — *no value exists yet.* Nothing has been realised, so there is nothing to be ignorant of. This is not a deficiency of any frame.
3. **indeterministic** — no structure fixes what the value will be. The present theory denies this (Section 17); it is listed to be excluded.

The distinction is operational rather than terminological. **Determination is an event, not a fact about a pre-existing value**: "undisclosed" presupposes a value already realised and merely unheld, whereas "undetermined" asserts that collapse is what produces one. A frame may act to *obtain* an undisclosed value; it can only *await or participate in* the collapse that determines an undetermined one; and a NULL dimension is not something it can look for at all.

This separation is what Proposition 12.4 states from the other side: a continuation may be determinable and undetermined simultaneously, since the first concerns what fixes it and the second whether it has happened.

**Definition 12.3** (The present, structurally)**.** *Within a frame, the present is the collapse boundary at which every instantiated* undetermined *dimension relevant to that collapse has been determined:*

$$\boxed{U_{\mathcal{F}} = 0.}$$

*$U_{\mathcal{F}}$ counts undetermined dimensions only. NULL dimensions are excluded — they are not variables.* ***Undisclosed dimensions are also excluded****: they are already determined, and a frame's failure to hold them is an epistemic deficit rather than an unresolved collapse. A frame with outstanding undisclosed structure is still at its own present.*

The present is therefore defined structurally rather than as a point on a primitive time axis, which is required given Section 13.

**Proposition 12.4** (Determinable is not determined)**.** *A continuation may be completely determinable from present structure without having been realised:*

$$\boxed{\textit{determinable} \neq \textit{determined}.}$$

*"Determined" is reserved for what has collapsed into realised history; a continuation that is determinable but not yet realised is* undetermined *in the sense of Definition 12.1, and this is not a statement about any frame's knowledge.*

**Proposition 12.5** (Causally sufficient present structure)**.** *The determining condition is structure instantiated* now*, including relevant containing-frame relations:*

$$\boxed{\textit{same causally sufficient present structure} \Rightarrow \textit{same realised continuation.}}$$

This replaces any formulation requiring a complete antecedent state *in time*. Only the present exists in a frame; past states need not remain extant, and the future is not an extant region lying ahead of the present. The future consists of reachable or determinable continuations represented now.

**Corollary 12.6** (History principle, strengthened)**.**

$$\boxed{\textit{history matters only where it survives as present structure.}}$$

*The past is surviving consequence instantiated now, not a stack of still-existing historical frames.*

Present structure is therefore *required* — it is the antecedent the next transition reads — while a history *record*, a stack of past states, is *optional* and in no way required by the dynamics. The causally relevant past already lives in the present structure (which is what the corollary says), so forgetting the record loses nothing the dynamics use: a graph with no history at all runs identically, the substrate's strong Markov property that the continuation depends only on the present and never on the path (Propositions 12.5, 8.2). A record is accordingly a paid copy kept for the copier — audit, replay, proof — and never funded by the process. Anterograde amnesia is the clean case: present structure (procedures, skills, the operative past) works while record-forming is broken; function needs the effects, never the diary. This is the past-directed half of "the future is not an extant region ahead": neither past nor future is a required region the graph moves through — there is present structure, and optional copies.

# 13 Time is not a dimension of the substrate

The claim here is stronger than non-primitivity, and stating the weaker version invites the wrong reading. It is not that time is nonlinear, or differently shaped, or emergent-but-still-there. It is that

**Axiom 0** (No substrate time dimension)**.** Time is not a first-class dimension of the substrate. *What the substrate has is* change*: realised collapses. It has no ratchet over and above them — no mechanism that manufactures succession — because the three properties usually bundled under that word are readings over changes or properties of them, not a further thing the substrate runs. The ordinal event order of Section 11 is carried by the changes' own enabling-relations; direction is the asymmetry of enablement itself — if one change makes another possible, the second does not thereby make the first possible, which holds whether or not a change preserves what it followed; and persistence is only that further changes occur. A time dimension exists only where a frame instantiates one* to represent *that order.*

*Remark* 13.1 (Even succession is not a substrate mechanism)*.* This removes the last piece of machinery the account might be read as keeping. Succession, an ordered "ratchet" turning under the changes, is to change what a metric time dimension is to succession — one level of over-structure, nameable but not required. Step the removal through: take away any posited succession-engine and the before/after is still present, carried by which change enables which; the arrow is still present, in the enabling relation's own asymmetry; the running is still present, as further changes occurring where rules fire. Nothing is lost, so the engine was never load-bearing. The substrate has change and the absence of change, and nothing between them.

**Proposition 13.2** (Time is observer machinery)**.** *For a frame $\mathcal{F}$,*

$$\boxed{T \in \mathcal{F} \iff \mathcal{F} \textit{ instantiates the relation representing succession.}}$$

*Otherwise $T =$* NULL *in that frame: absent, not set to a value. A substrate frame that realises continuations without representing succession has no temporal dimension at all, and nothing about its dynamics is thereby incomplete.*

The distinction that carries the axiom is between *succession* and *time*. Succession is a relation among realised changes, carried by which change enables which; it is substrate-level in that sense, not a mechanism the substrate runs over and above the changes. Time is a represented dimension, and representing something requires a frame that represents it. Only an agent — in the minimal sense of a frame that instantiates the representing relation — observes time.

Schematically, and without pretending to explain the first arrow,

$$? \dashrightarrow G \xrightarrow{\text{realised change}} \text{changes, enabling-order carried} \xrightarrow{\text{a frame represents an order}} T \in \mathcal{F}.$$

The second arrow is substrate dynamics. The third is representation, and it is optional.

**Proposition 13.3** (Time is inferred, not observed)**.** *No collapse presents a temporal coordinate. Succession is a relation* between *realised states, and a relation between states is not a datum of any one of them. A frame therefore acquires a time dimension only by* inferring *it from the relations among what it holds. Consequently*

$$\boxed{\textit{a frame observes time} \implies \textit{that frame is capable of inference.}}$$

**Corollary 13.4** (Reactive frames have succession and no time)**.** *A frame that transforms under the Graph Law without inferring relations among its held states participates fully in realised change and has $T =$* NULL*. Nothing in its dynamics is thereby impaired: change is what the substrate supplies and the order among changes is carried by them, while time is what an inferring frame constructs from that order.*

*Remark* 13.5 (A rate has no in-frame denominator). A realised delta is a difference, not a difference *per* anything: what a frame holds is $\Delta$, never $\Delta/\Delta T$, because $\Delta T$ is the inferred dimension of Proposition 13.3 and is not available in-frame to divide by. A rate is thus a second construction — an observer dividing an accumulated $\Delta$ by its own count of writes — and is cross-frame in the same sense that a metric duration is. Two things have to be held apart here. The *inputs* are the frame's own and nothing external is smuggled in: $\Delta$ is what it holds and the cycle count is what Proposition 13.7 says it counts, both integer, both in-frame. The *quotient* is not an in-frame quantity for that reason — a ratio of two integers is not generally an integer, and a frame's coordinates are the integer lattice. So a rate is in-frame in its provenance and cross-frame in its type, which is the general discipline applied to this case rather than an exception to it: the division is a map between readings, and maps are where non-integer structure is allowed to live. The Narrativium companion's reconciliation is right about the provenance and this remark is right about the type; neither has to give way. This is why a substrate law must be stated in $\Delta$ rather than in a rate: "constant motion" is the standing structure persisting without a write (Remark 4.3), its momentum quantity a difference $\Delta$ and not a velocity. It also diagnoses a familiar regress in constructed learners, where every adaptive rate is found to need a reference rate without end: the regress is the signature of placing a cross-frame quantity in-frame, and it disappears when the held quantity is the difference itself.

This orders two capabilities that are usually treated as independent. Inference is not a faculty a temporal agent happens to have; it is the precondition for being a temporal agent at all. It also grades: the temporal structure a frame holds is bounded by the inferential structure it can construct, so "how much time" a frame has is a question about its inference and not about the world.

*Remark* 13.6 (Empirical instance). This is measurable rather than merely stipulative, and it has been measured. A perceptual system given ordered frames and no temporal coordinate infers a transition generator carrying one frame to the next, and the integer count of applications *is* the time axis it then holds; given the same frames shuffled, it infers none. The dimension was not supplied to it and does not exist in the observations — it exists in the map between them, once something constructs it. Notably, the mechanism that constructs it is the system's general *dimension-inference* machinery, not a temporal faculty: time is minted by the same operation that mints any other unobserved dimension, which is Proposition 13.3 in implementation.

**Proposition 13.7** (The unit of inferred time is a cycle, and requires closure)**.** *A frame does not count its individual changes — those are below its aperture — but its own* cycles*, each one traversal of a closed rule-loop. The unit of inferred time is therefore a cycle, not a change, and a cycle has no fixed length: each does a variable amount of change, so inferred time is non-uniform in underlying change (a nonlinear grounding, which Discrete Sufficiency already permits) and a fuller cycle reads as a longer moment (subjective dilation). A cycle exists only for a graph with* closure *— a graph without it runs to fixed point once and stops, one pass and no repeated tick — so having time requires closure as well as inference (Proposition 13.3): a one-shot computation, lacking a loop to iterate, has no time, and a frame's experienced "now" is one cycle of its own loop.*

*Remark* 13.8 (The processor is a constructible demonstration). A running program is a worked instance, carried by most people on earth. An instruction is the program's step, and it does not take a fixed physical time: an addition is one cycle, a memory load one on a cache hit and hundreds on a miss, a branch may stall, and the core reorders and overlaps beneath it. Yet from the program's point of view every instruction is *one* step — its own unit, read as 1 by construction, since a step is a step — so the program's inferred time is its step-count, uniform to it and non-uniform in physical time. The variable timing's *mechanism* is opaque to the program — the cache miss and the reorder are below its aperture, beneath its primitives (Proposition 14.4) — while its *effects* are not, since a program can time its own reads and infer what it cannot see, which is the leak of Proposition 14.2 and the basis of the attacks cited there, which is why "time is a variable-length cycle, not a fixed duration" reads as exotic even though the device demonstrates it continuously. How much weight this carries requires separating two things, and the separation recovers something real.

The *vocabulary* is borrowed and carries no weight whatever. Aperture, runner, primitive, cost: this account took them from engineering (Section 18), so terminological agreement between the two is not agreement about anything, and a reader who notices that this reads like computing has noticed only that.

What is not borrowed is that computing was *forced* to these arrangements. The right question is not why this account looks like computers but why computers look like this — and the answer, case by case, is that engineers fought each of these features and lost. Nobody wanted a memory hierarchy; it exists because latency and bandwidth do not scale together. Nobody wanted instructions of unequal duration; they exist because operations genuinely cost differently. Nobody wanted opacity between levels; it exists because complexity must be bounded to be buildable at all. And nobody wanted to give up a global clock: distributed systems have no shared instant because signal speed is finite, which is a theorem rather than a preference (Lamport, 1978), and the resulting architecture is a concession to physics that engineering resisted for as long as it could (Chapiro, 1984; Brewer, 2000).

So the convergence is not that two descriptions sound alike. It is that a discipline optimising hard against cost, with no interest in metaphysics and every incentive to avoid each of these features, arrived at cycle-as-variable-unit, per-frame logical time, per-level opacity and cost inherited along provision — because the constraints that force them are the constraints this account claims are the operative ones. That is evidence about the constraints, and it survives the borrowed vocabulary because it does not run through it.

The honest limit is that computing's designers are people, so convergence could reflect shared cognition rather than shared constraint. What answers that is the forcing arguments themselves being physical — finite signal speed, finite bandwidth, a thermodynamic floor — rather than matters of taste, and Lamport's result in particular being a proof about what is available given a finite $c$, not a design that could have gone otherwise.

*Remark* 13.9 (Physics groundings are developed in a companion). The reading of $c$ as a frame's own change-throughput unit, and the shapes that follow from it — the invariance of $c$ as a theorem, the reconciliation of special and general relativity as one change-budget spent on motion or on change-load, the dimensional constants as frame-units with the uncertainty principle and the Landauer floor among them, the Planck scale as the frontier, and the second law as no-copy accumulation — are developed in the companion paper, *Graphic Equalisation — Physics Grounding*. They are information-level groundings in the sense of Section 1, and are kept out of the present paper so that the substrate theory stands without them.

# Part V
# Provenance and its limit

## 14 Primitives, and the closure of their provenance

The provenance of $r$ (Section 1) records that operative transformation requires something that performs it. What performs it is real; naming it as a thing is the error this section avoids, because a graph never meets it. What a graph meets is its *primitives*.

**Definition 14.1** (Primitives)**.** *A graph's* primitives *are the operations it invokes without performing: the operator set its rules bottom out in. Every level has them, and having them is what being a level consists of — a graph with no primitives would have to perform everything it invokes, which is the regress this substrate does not contain. That is the whole of the definition, and in particular it says nothing about what a graph can learn of where they come from.*

*Two different things can be meant by provenance being hidden, and running them together inverts the relation between them.*

Deliberate exposure — *state maintained so that what runs on it can read it, as reflection does — is structure doing work for something other than the frame holding it, and is therefore excluded by well-formedness (Definition 7.7) in the ordinary way: it costs, and the frame supplying it gets nothing.*

Leakage *is the opposite case and is not excluded at all. A cache earns its retention many times over and leaks precisely* because *it does work; an arithmetic fast enough to overflow at a word boundary discloses the boundary by being fast; a page-sized performance cliff exists because the page size is doing something. Every leak in Proposition 14.2 is a consequence of efficient design rather than of poor design, so well-formedness does not prevent leakage — it* produces *it, and a structure that leaked nothing would have given up the optimisations that distinguish it from a uniform one, which is what constant-time implementations do and what they pay for.*

**Proposition 14.2** (Primitives leak, and complete provenance is still unrecoverable)**.** *Leaking is ordinary rather than exceptional. A primitive's timing discloses the structure beneath it, which is why measuring how long a read takes recovers what a cache holds (Osvik et al., 2006; Kocher et al., 2019); an arithmetic that overflows at a particular magnitude discloses a word size; a rounding discloses a representation; and a performance cliff at a particular size discloses a page. Most abstractions leak, and this one is not special.*

*How a leak reaches a frame at all is worth stating, since what falls outside an aperture is* absent *(Definition 7.2) and an absent thing cannot disclose anything. It does not arrive by*

*perception. What arrives is an ordinary in-frame observable on a dimension the frame already instantiates — a duration in its own units, a value at a boundary — and what the frame does with it is* infer*. The cache is not perceived; the timings are, and the cache is concluded from them.*

*What does not follow is that provenance can be recovered entire. Every act of recovery is itself performed by primitives, so a graph inferring what lies beneath one operator does so using others whose own provenance is not thereby in view, and there is no position from which the whole supply is inspected at once. The result is the standing shape:* partial always, complete never *— leaks give a graph real and sometimes decisive knowledge of what supplies it, and never the closure of that question.*

This is what the physics companion's treatment of $c$ turns on rather than contradicts. A frame cannot read the rate beneath its primitives directly, and has nonetheless obtained a number for it by measurement and inference across three centuries — which is exploiting a leak, and is available precisely because provenance is not sealed.

**Proposition 14.3** (Primitives are supplied, not intrinsic)**.** *A graph is data — nodes, relations, and rules — and the operations its rules bottom out in are supplied to it rather than contained in it. The same graph may therefore be run against different supplies of the same operator set, and nothing supplying an operator need be the substrate the graph describes or is "in." Where the work is done is a fact about that supply and not about the graph.*

At one extreme the coupling is tight — the graph is fused to what supplies it, as matter running its own change or a mind running on the tissue that is it — and the compute is local, in the graph, inseparable. At the other it is loose — the graph is data executed by a separate interpreter — and the compute is done in the runner, elsewhere, while the graph becomes portable: copyable, relocatable, and run at whatever rate the runner supplies (Section 13). This separability is the condition for the copyable-generator and clock-independence results (Proposition 7.13, and the Seldon paper's dependent-clock remark): a graph welded to what supplies it has none of them, a graph loosely coupled has all of them.

**Proposition 14.4** (A well-formed runner does not expose itself, and no level is self-transparent)**.** *The asynchronous, locally synchronous structure a frame observes (Remark 11.3) is the graph's* internal *view and does not fix its runner's actual mode. A hidden central runner may execute a graph serially, one change at a time, while the graph — lacking any access to the runner's clock — appears asynchronous and concurrent to itself. More generally, where a frame has no boundary to the substrate that runs it, its runner lies beyond the frame's epistemic boundary in exactly the sense of Section 1.*

*Calling the runner unseeable rather than unseen runs two claims together. That a runner is hidden is* contingent*. Nothing forbids a runner from exposing its own state to what it runs, and computational reflection does exactly that, as this paper acknowledges when placing itself against that literature (Section 18); a tower in which each level is available to the one above is a built artefact, not a thought experiment. A runner that does not expose itself is the* well-formed *case, and for the reasons well-formedness always turns on: exposed runner state is structure maintained for work the frame does not do, and each exposure needs a runner of its own to run the reading of it.*

*What does not depend on the cost model is weaker and survives reflection:* no level is self-transparent*. Reading is an operation whose product lands one level up (Remark 7.9), so a level cannot hold the reading of itself while being the level that is running. Reflection makes the levels explicit and pays for each; it does not terminate in a level transparent to itself. A frame may therefore be given sight of what runs it, and cannot be given sight of its own running. Since the rules are graph and a frame can read and rewrite them (Definition 6.2), while its own running is not graph it holds, the asymmetry is exact: a frame is transparent to itself in precisely one*

*respect and opaque in precisely the other.* It can know what it is and cannot observe its being it. *Self-modification is available; self-observation at the level of the modifying is not.*

This is constructively demonstrable rather than merely argued. A computation realised inside another rule system — a graph whose rules are implemented within the mechanics of a game or a universal cellular automaton (Berlekamp et al., 1982) — is a blind subframe: from inside it computes at its own change-count and has no means to detect that its "compute" is the tokens of the host, or that the host may be advancing it by a single serial loop. Building one confirms the opacity directly, and puts the observer of any frame on the same footing. Consequently the question "where is the universe's compute done" has the precise form: it asks after the provenance of the universe's own primitives — self-supplied, or supplied from a substrate not itself — and is undetermined from inside. The theory declines to decide it; it is a question about a coupling below the frontier, and the demonstrable opacity is why no internal observation settles it.

**Proposition 14.5** (A primitive is another graph's running, exposed)**.** *Nothing supplying a primitive is a substance apart from graph data. An operator is the observable running of some other graph, which has primitives of its own, supplied in the same way. A graph's "primitives" are therefore the observable running of other graphs, exposed as an operator set, with no primitive runner at the base. A single chain — code over machine code over microcode over silicon over electromagnetism over quantum physics — is one path through that provision, and a common one, but not its shape: a process takes arithmetic from its processor, file operations from a kernel that relays them to a device, and remote calls from a machine that is not beneath it in any sense. Fan-out and relay are ordinary, and the tower is the degenerate case in which provision happens to be a chain. The regress bottoms not at a floor but at the epistemic frontier of Section 1: below the lowest measured level is the unclaimed pre-relational substrate.*

Two consequences. Opacity is per *operator* rather than per level (Proposition 14.4): a graph uses its operators and cannot see beneath any of them, so its operator set is its frontier — and since provision may fan out, it cannot tell which of its operators share a provider and which do not. Two primitives supplied by one supergraph and two supplied by different ones are in-frame indistinguishable, so a graph does not know how many runners it has, or that the number is one. And economics is inherited along provision: an operator costs what the runner of that operator charges, which costs what *its* providers charge, down to whatever floors each route reaches (Remark 7.8). Where provision is a chain this is one bill passed upward, and the cost of a thought is the biological cost is the biochemical cost is the electromagnetic cost; where it is not, it is a sum over provenances whose routes may differ in length and may not all terminate at the same floor. The same form, graph data that runs, sits at every level: each level *is* the structure, because a runner is the same kind of thing it runs.

A rule's action, moreover, is a *pointer* into its runner, not a copy of the work. The work is done once, in the runner, and every rule invoking that operator points to the same doing — like a shared operation defined once and called from everywhere, never re-implemented. Two things follow. Work is never duplicated, which is why copying a generator copies its pointers and shares the pointed-to work: the copy costs only its addressing, not its labour (the economic root of the copyable-generator result, Proposition 7.13). And a rule's rate is not a property of the rule but the rate of the operation its pointer lands on — a shallow, cheap tier or a deep, slow one. Rules take different rates because they point to work done at different depths of the stack, and the rate is inherited from there rather than assigned as a knob on the rule: to make a rule faster one points its action at faster work, never tunes a rate parameter it does not have.

# 15 The single prohibition, and its formal core

The account forbids very little, and what it does forbid is one thing recurring rather than a list. Stating both facts together is necessary because each is misleading alone.

The permissiveness first. Time is not compulsory; a block reading is not prohibited; one-dimensional time is not forced; a globally shared counter is not forbidden, only expensive; and in the physics companion, complex amplitudes are not forced and the one-way speed of light is not unmeasurable *simpliciter*. A framework that forbids little predicts little, and from outside this is exactly what unfalsifiability looks like. The discriminating question is not how many impossibilities an account holds but where it puts them: this one puts almost none at the substrate and a great many in the groundings, and says in advance which is which. That is deliberate and it has a cost, which should be stated rather than defended — the substrate risks little, and what risk this work carries is carried by the groundings. A reviewer who objects that the substrate forbids too little to be tested is right about the substrate.

What it forbids is that *a frame cannot get outside itself*. Concretely, and confined to what is actually derivable here: a frame cannot be transparent to itself at the level it is running at (Proposition 14.4); it cannot measure its own throughput in units independent of it, since the measurement is funded by the throughput — which leaves a number obtainable and its absolute scale not; and it cannot hold a view from nowhere, which is Axiom −1. Two further candidates are deliberately *not* on this list. That a frame cannot obtain a quantity whose unit does not close within it is contingent rule content and the physics companion removes it explicitly. That a frame cannot decide anything without writing is the write-economics, which Remark 7.12 carries as a pattern rather than a universal. Folding either into the single prohibition would be the over-unification this section otherwise warns against.

This is not a fourth answer to what is compulsory, and the paper should not read as though it were. Remark 7.11 says only that rules run is compulsory; rules running requires a relation across which they run, so the container relation is not an addition to that but its content. The prohibition is not a further necessity alongside them: it is a constraint that holds wherever rules run at all, which is why it is not rule content and cannot be varied by changing the rules.

## The formal analogue

The standing of that prohibition is unlike the rest of this paper, and the difference should be stated exactly, including where it falls short. The rest of what is claimed here is contingent rule content. The impossibility of a level being transparent to itself has a *formal analogue*, and the analogue is proved — in mathematics rather than in physics, so it does not depend on any fact about which universe this is.

A consistent, effectively axiomatised formal system with enough arithmetic strength — from which the expressibility of its own syntax follows, by numbering, rather than being assumed — does not prove its own *Gödel sentence*, which is nonetheless true in the standard model of arithmetic (Gödel, 1931). A language of sufficient strength cannot define its own truth predicate under classical bivalent semantics; truth for it must be given in a metalanguage (Tarski, 1936). And no single procedure decides halting for arbitrary procedures — a limit on what a universal procedure can decide, and one that arises *because* such a procedure exists rather than in spite of it (Turing, 1936). These are not three coincidences: they share one diagonal construction, and the categorical statement of it makes the unity explicit (Lawvere, 1969; Yanofsky, 2003). Tarski's is the tightest fit — the semantics of a level is available only from above it, which is Proposition 14.4's surviving half in the vocabulary of formal languages.

Four qualifications, none of them optional.

The theorems carry hypotheses that must be carried with them: effective axiomatisability and sufficient strength for the first, classical bivalence for the second — a language may contain its own truth predicate at the cost of bivalence (Kripke, 1975) — and, for all of them, that a

system be strong enough to represent its own operation before any of it bites. A frame too weak to model itself has no self-transparency problem, because it has no self-model.

The unification covers what is claimed above and not more. Gödel's *second* incompleteness theorem — that such a system cannot prove its own consistency — is the more striking result and is not covered by the unification as published: Lawvere (1969) closes by noting that extending to it may require a specific relation between formulas and their numbers that his framework does not supply, while Yanofsky (2003) treats it as a simple consequence of the first and expects the scheme to reach it. The claim here is made with the first theorem, which the unification does cover, and takes no position on the second.

The mapping from frames to formal systems is an argument in this paper and not itself a theorem. What is proved is proved about the formal systems. The honest statement is therefore that the impossibility has a formal analogue whose analogue is proved, and that the mapping is argued — which is weaker than "the prohibition is proved" and is the strongest standing anything here has.

And the substrate-internal derivation of the same conclusion, by way of a read being an operation whose product lands one level up (Remark 7.9), inherits the write-economics' contingency and does not establish a necessity. Remark 7.12 carries that economics as a pattern open to counterexample, and §19 stakes a falsifier on it. The formal analogue is what carries the weight here precisely because it does not depend on the economics; the internal derivation alone cannot bear the necessity.

What the results forbid is *complete* self-capture and not partial self-modelling, which is why reflective towers work, arithmetic is not paralysed, and a frame can know a great deal about itself. Partial always, complete never — and the asymptote in that is not a figure of speech, since a diagonal argument does not say a target is far away but that for any level reached there is another above it, and none is the last.

*Remark* 15.1 (Decay is the frame's side of a balance). Nothing above adds a tendency to fall apart, and none is needed. Continuation is a default and not a guarantee (Proposition 7.6): standing structure persists because nothing changed it, which is the absence of an event rather than a force resisting one. So the question is not why things decay. It is why anything would not.

A coupled frame sits in a container that runs, so changes arrive across the boundary. To persist *as what it is*, those arrivals must compose into no net change to the structure that individuates it — and what arrives without cohering is residual (Definition 8.1). Decay is residual accumulating at a boundary, in the vocabulary already here.

Which makes the observed universality unsurprising rather than a further law, because observation is coupling. To observe something is to stand in a relation across which something passes, so an observed frame is a coupled one and a coupled frame is one being acted on. *Being observable and being acted upon are the same condition.* An uncoupled frame need not decay, and no one can check, which is Axiom -1 doing ordinary work rather than a gap.

That leaves three cases, and a fourth that is admissible and unattested — arrivals that happen to cohere, leaving a coupled frame neither decaying nor sustained. Nothing forbids it; it is what the falsifier below asks for. Where the container does not pay, the frame decays. Where it pays, the frame is maintained — and homeostasis, error correction, repair and refresh are all that case, which is why each is expensive. Where there is no coupling there is neither, and nothing observes it. This is Proposition 7.4 read at persistence: holding structure against arrivals is preventing a change, preventing a change is itself a change, and what is not paid for is not, on any record anyone has, observed to happen. The falsifier inherits from there — an observed frame that neither decays nor has a sustaining container, a persistence with no payment traced on inspection of both sides.

The reading is tidy enough to be suspected, so two cautions. *Intrinsic* decay is not a counterexample and not a separate kind: modelling a nucleus alone makes its decay intrinsic

and modelling it with its container makes the same event an interaction, so the distinction is where a boundary was drawn rather than a fact about the event. And the step from *persisting is narrow* to *decay is general* should not be read as counting outcomes, because Proposition 14.2 makes write-counts across differing provenance chains non-commensurable. It runs on coherence being a narrow *condition* — the arrivals must compose to nothing — and not on there being more ways to fail it.

# Part VI
# Carvings and determinism

## 16 Carvings, and why classification degrades

Since the rules draw the boundary (Definition 6.2) and the rules are contingent, frames are *arbitrary*, and the objection that follows should be met rather than deferred: a notion satisfied by any cut explains nothing.

The first half is granted and is the point. No carving is privileged, nothing in the substrate marks which subgraphs are the real ones, and this is Axiom −1 reaching the last place a privileged view could still have been hiding — not in the observer, not in what it observes, but in what counts as an observer at all. A rock is a frame, an imagining is a frame, a population is a frame, and none of these is an inclusiveness conceded for breadth.

The second half does not follow, because arbitrary is not unconstrained. The rule set must be admissible; a frame whose rules never close a cycle has no unit, no inferred time and nothing to observe with; and well-formedness is graded (Definition 7.7), so a badly drawn frame is expensive, incoherent or blind while remaining a frame. Any cut is a frame and nearly every cut is a poor one — the same shape as the rest of this account, in which almost nothing is forbidden and the differences are prices.

The mechanism of that price is worth stating exactly, because the obvious statement of it is wrong under this paper's own economics. Holding a classification is not itself expensive: Proposition 7.6 makes the standing structure's persistence free. What an ill-formed cut costs is *writes*. A cut that does not fit what arrives forces its rules to write against the standing structure repeatedly, where a well-formed one rarely needs to — which is the observation already recorded after that proposition. And no selection principle follows from this: nothing in the substrate removes expensive structure. What follows is weaker and sufficient, that a frame under a budget will tend to be running cheaper cuts than dearer ones, other things equal.

**Proposition 16.1** (Convergence is observed, not enforced)**.** *Two frames doing the same work converge on similar cuts as each becomes better formed, because the cheap cut for a given task is nearly unique. This is a tendency of cost and not the discovery of a privileged boundary, and the two are distinguishable in principle: a privileged boundary would* enforce *convergence, and enforcement would extend to the hard cases; cost-shaped cuts converge where the work is shared and come apart where it is not. The step from shared work to similar cuts assumes the cheap cut for a task is nearly unique, which is an empirical posit and not a result of this account; it is labelled again where it is used (Proposition 16.2).*

What follows belongs here, after the proposition it follows from, rather than upstream of the premise a reader needs to have met.

**Proposition 16.2** (Convergence under compression)**.** *A structure operating under a constraint, and under pressure to spend nothing on what does no work, approaches the arrangements that constraint forces — asymptotically, and only over the region the constraint touches. Two such structures therefore come to resemble each other without either having access to the other, because both are downstream of the same forcing rather than converging on a target.*

Three things about that statement are load-bearing.

It names no privileged arrangement. Structures approaching *the arrangements a universe already uses* would reintroduce exactly the privileged carving Proposition 16.1 denies, and additionally attributes work and purpose to a universe, which this account does not do and which that proposition's antecedent requires. What converges is the solution a constraint forces; a universe's arrangements are one thing that constraint has shaped, not a destination anything aims at.

The antecedent is about *expenditure* and not about contents. Stating it the other way — as pressure to hold nothing idle — would make the proposition false of every case it is applied to (Definition 7.7).

It rests on a posit that should be labelled rather than folded in. The step from *under a constraint* to *approaches the same arrangement* needs the cheap solution under a given constraint to be nearly unique — and that is an empirical claim, not a result of this account. It is not derived here and it is not derived in Proposition 16.1 either, which asserts it in the same words. What can be said without it is weaker: a binding constraint narrows the solution space, and the more binding it is the narrower it gets. Everything below rests on the weak form.

And the rate is set by how binding the pressure is. A domain with slack to spend on anything but cost converges slowly or not at all; one optimising hard against cost per unit of function converges fast. Computing is the second kind, which is why it is the worked instance and why decades sufficed.

*Remark* 16.3 (Evolution under the same treatment: independent where computing is not, and weaker where computing is strong)*.* Descent with modification is compressed in the required sense — energy, time and reproduction are all scarce, and the pressure falls on what is *spent* rather than on what is carried.

Whether that makes it a better instance than computing depends on which axis is asked, and an earlier version of this remark asserted superiority on both, which is not available. On *independence* it is decisively better and this is the axis the argument needs: computing shares this account's vocabulary and is disqualified for it, whereas biology shares neither vocabulary nor personnel, and its convergences were catalogued long before anything here was written. On the *antecedent* the ranking reverses. The rate law above sets convergence by how binding the pressure is, and computing was named the hard-optimising kind for a reason; biology is the slack kind, since selection is efficacious only where its coefficient exceeds the reciprocal of effective population size, so structure whose cost falls below that line is invisible to it and persists (Ohta, 1973). Biology is therefore a *sufficient* instance on the antecedent rather than a superior one, and the paragraph that follows is the work of establishing that sufficiency rather than a defence of a stronger claim.

An objection is worth meeting here rather than leaving to a reader, because it looks decisive and is not. Genomes conspicuously carry structure that does no work — pseudogenes, transposon debris, whole duplicated regions — which appears to fail the antecedent outright. It does not, because the antecedent is about spending. *Inert sequence is the cost of its own deletion, represented.* Carrying it costs replication, and it costs search — more sequence to traverse, more places a regulatory element could be, more targets for recombination — but each of those is small and continuous, while removing it is a single write that risks excising something that turns out to matter. So it persists wherever the accumulated search cost has not yet overtaken the cost of the write, which is most of the time. Constructive neutral evolution is that observation made precisely rather than a counterexample to it (Stoltzfus, 1999; Lukeš et al., 2011).

The concession also earns something, because the weakness just admitted makes a quantitative prediction the account would otherwise not get. If inert sequence persists exactly where its cost sits below what selection can resolve, then how much of it a lineage carries should track that threshold — less in large populations where selection is efficacious, more in small ones where it is not. That inverse relation between genome bloat and effective population size is observed,

and has been argued to be the explanation of genome size itself (Lynch and Conery, 2003).

The reading is contested (Whitney and Garland, 2010), and that is the expected condition rather than a weakness in it. What the economics predicts is a *trend*, and it is not entitled to more. The three costs vary independently across lineages, and so do mutation rate, deletion bias, recombination and transposon activity, so nothing here licenses a clean relation — and a clean one would indicate a single dominant term the account does not posit. The exposure is accordingly to *direction* and not to tightness: a phylogenetically corrected null leaves the account where it was, whereas bloat tracking effective population size *positively* would contradict it outright. That is a weak commitment and is stated at its strength. It is also the same commitment made twice already — convergence is observed and not enforced (Proposition 16.1), and cheapness is a tendency of cost rather than the discovery of a joint — so reading a trend as a trend is this account's standing position and not an accommodation made once the evidence turned out noisy.

The same shape appears wherever the same economics does, which is the point rather than an aside. Dead code survives in working systems for the identical reason, and shows the later costs plainly because people pay them. Leaving it is nearly free per line; the accumulated search cost is that everything is harder to find; and the cost that forces the issue is a change made carefully to a path nothing executes — paid in full, returning nothing, and leaving its author believing the system was altered. Repair machinery maintaining non-functional sequence is the same expenditure one level down. Neither is certain waste, since inert structure is sometimes being prepared for reuse and dead paths are sometimes revived, so what grows with the held quantity is the *expected* share of effort that lands on nothing.

That last hedge is not a formality, and the case that makes it concrete also explains why removal is expensive in a way the preceding paragraphs only asserted. The vermiform appendix was classified as vestigial for over a century, on Darwin's own reading, and removed routinely on that basis; it is now argued to serve as a reservoir from which gut flora can repopulate the colon after the contents are lost (Bollinger et al., 2007), and to have arisen independently many times across mammals, which is not what a functionless remnant does (Smith et al., 2013).

The lesson is not that the appendix turned out useful. It is that *inertness is a judgement made at an aperture, and the judgement fails* — something was called structure-that-does-nothing by people looking carefully, for a hundred years, at the wrong scale. Why that judgement cannot be made cheaply is treated generally in Section 9: the dependents of a structure are held in other frames and not in it (Remark 9.5), and establishing inertness requires the perturbation that *is* the removal one wanted licensed (Remark 9.4). Retention is therefore the ordinary outcome and a correct one, and a lineage or a codebase that pruned aggressively would be the anomaly requiring explanation.

*Convergent evolution* is Proposition 16.2 with a name biology gave it first. Independent lineages arrive at the camera eye, the streamlined body, the wing, and they do so because optics, fluid dynamics and lift are the same wherever they are met, and the catalogue is large (McGhee, 2011). In the cases named here the forcing constraint can be stated, which is what this account requires of a convergence before it counts; that it can be stated in *every* case is not claimed, and how far convergence indicates inevitability is itself disputed (Losos, 2017). Nothing was copied and nothing had access to anything.

The change side is the same economics read the other way, and it gives a second correspondence. In this account change is paid and persistence is free to the frame, so a structure changes when what it meets will not cohere with what it holds and not otherwise — which is stasis as the default and change as the forced exception, the shape the fossil record was read as showing when long stable intervals were argued to be punctuated by short rapid ones (Eldredge and Gould, 1972). Read in the substrate's terms, selection is the residual gate: variation is undirected and cheap, and what is expensive is the rewriting that follows when the residual will not fit.

*Grain is set by the environment.* How finely a lineage discriminates is not chosen by it but

forced by what it meets, which is the aperture claim of Section 7 in another grounding, and it is why the same organism is coarse in one setting and finely differentiated in another.

The consequence for this paper's own composition claim is the deflation stated in Section 1: if recurrence is what compressed structures do, what a recurrence evidences is the constraint and not the arrangement, and the composition falsifier is negative-only. The test that remains is not *a domain not under these constraints*, which is empty — every physical domain is under finite signal speed, finite bandwidth and a thermodynamic floor. It is a domain under *weak* compression: somewhere with slack, where cost pressure is not binding, and where the arrangement should therefore be absent. Ritual, ornament, and systems maintained past their purpose are candidates. Finding the arrangement there, rendered with equal facility, would show the vocabulary doing the work.

That proposition is the paper's discriminating test between privileged-carving realism and cost-shaped pluralism, and the systematics literature is where it can be run. The competing species concepts do converge, on a common notion of a separately evolving lineage, with the long dispute reinterpreted as disagreement over operational criteria rather than over the concept (de Queiroz, 2007) — and that convergence is what this account predicts rather than what embarrasses it. Whether it is *enforced* is the open question, and de Queiroz himself holds the boundaries to be real but epistemically hard, which is the opposing horn honestly stated; the criteria continue to disagree hardest over asexual organisms, bacteria exchanging genes horizontally and recent divergences. This paper does not claim the case is settled in its favour. It claims the case is a test.

The wider prediction is that classification degrades in a *located* way rather than uniformly, and it must be stated with the operationalisation that makes it a test.

**Hypothesis 16.4** (Located degradation)**.** *Where a classification's purpose can be specified independently and in advance of inspecting its failures, the failures concentrate near the boundary of that purpose more than a uniform distribution over the domain would produce. The claim is comparative and is not that failures occur nowhere else.*

The advance-specification clause is what keeps this from circularity, and it is a real constraint: a purpose read off from where the failures already are confirms nothing. Independent evidence exists elsewhere — classification systems in institutional use are documented as leaking wherever they have been examined closely, carrying residual categories and encoding their builders' purposes (Bowker and Star, 1999) — and that literature's concept of *torque* — the twisting of a person's own trajectory against a standardised classification that does not fit it — is a closer instrument for this hypothesis than leakage is, with the qualification that its subject is a biography rather than a use.

Further results bear on the general claim without establishing it. No clustering function satisfies scale-invariance, richness and consistency together (Kleinberg, 2002) — but the same paper shows any two of the three are jointly achievable, so what is established is that the three cannot be had at once rather than that no cut is canonical. Kleinberg reads it that way himself, and dismisses a canonicity result for single-linkage cited on his second page as resting on a property that is an implicit optimisation criterion which single-linkage uniquely optimises; that dismissal is his, and is noted here rather than relied on. It is a trade-off theorem, not an impossibility of carving, and it is a deliberate transplant of Arrow's method rather than an independent convergence — the paper says so. And the question of which predicates are projectible has no syntactic answer (Goodman, 1955), which is usually reported as a defeat. Goodman's own criterion is *entrenchment*, a record of a predicate's having been *projected* before — a history of use and deliberately not a history of success, so it does not license reading entrenchment as tracking what has been cheap to run. The resemblance to a cost criterion is not evidence for one.

The constructive response is this paper's own and needs no companion: if the trouble is a cut fixed in advance, do not fix one. Corollary 8.4 already gives the mechanism — recognition and growth as one operation, joined where the residual meets the grammar that admits it — so a category is minted only where what arrived will not fit, and the codebook grows rather than the cut being defended. That recovers no privileged carving, because there is none, and does not need to.

The position is not new, and its nearest neighbour differs in grounding rather than in conclusion. A pluralism admitting many equally legitimate and equally real classifications, none of them the one nature intended, is argued at length (Dupré, 1993); that argument rests on objective similarity structure, where this one rests on what a cut costs to run, which is the more deflationary footing and reintroduces a ranking over cuts that "equally legitimate" was formulated to deny. The convergence is on the negative thesis; the divergence in grounding is real and is not smoothed over here.

# 17 Determinism and apparent stochasticity

**Proposition 17.1** (Graph-law determinism)**.** *For a fully specified antecedent configuration—including the graph state, operative transformation structure, admissibility grammar, and every causally operative containing relation relevant to the collapse—the realised continuation is determined:*

$$\boxed{\left(G_t, \mathcal{R}_t^{\text{causal}}\right) \mapsto G_{t+1}.}$$

*The Graph Law contains no primitive random actualisation operator.*

Proposition 17.1 is to be read through Proposition 12.5: the antecedent configuration is causally sufficient *present* structure, not a retained temporal history. Determinism is a relation between present structure and realised continuation, and Proposition 12.4 keeps it from being overstated — a determinable continuation is not thereby a determined one.

Apparent stochasticity arises when a frame does not represent all of the causally operative dimensions or relations required to determine the realised continuation. A probability distribution may then be an appropriate model of that frame's uncertainty, but the probability belongs to the incomplete representation rather than to the substrate transition itself. Treating probability as a representation of incomplete information has a long statistical-mechanical and Bayesian lineage (Jaynes, 1957).

Thus

| stochastic observation = deterministic dynamics viewed through unresolved causal structure. |
|---|

*Remark* 17.2 (Direction of the borrowing)*.* The order of discovery ran from quantum measurement outward, not from a general primitive inward. Collapse was adopted because compatibility with quantum measurement is a constraint on any theory of realised change, and was then assumed to hold generally. The bridge is therefore stated conditionally because the *generalisation* is the conjecture, not because the compatibility is in doubt. This is the structure of a promoted constraint — a fact that must hold in one regime, assumed to hold everywhere, with the consequences derived and exposed to falsification — and it is why Section 19 carries a falsifier for the bridge specifically. Origin does not establish a claim; the falsifier is what does the work either way.

The distinction of Remark 12.2 is what makes quantum measurement the visible case for the conditional collapse bridge (Remark 17.2). In that regime the pre-measurement alternatives provably cannot be re-read as an *undisclosed* already-realised classical value: Bell's theorem excludes the local hidden-variable class and Kochen–Specker constrains noncontextual value assignment (Bell, 1964; Kochen and Specker, 1967). What remains is *undetermined* in the

strict sense — not a value withheld, but no value yet. Elsewhere the two readings are usually interchangeable in practice; there they are not.

Deterministic quantum models demonstrate that empirical quantum statistics do not by themselves force fundamental stochasticity: Bohm's hidden-variable construction is explicitly deterministic (Bohm, 1952), while the constraints just cited rule out the local and noncontextual hidden-variable classes rather than determinism as such. Graphic Equalisation does not identify itself with Bohmian mechanics; these results establish only that determinism must be distinguished from locality and noncontextuality.

A stochastic law may be bolted onto a grounding as an epistemic predictive model over unresolved continuations. Doing so is an additional modelling layer:

$$\text{deterministic Graph Law} \longrightarrow \text{frame-limited uncertainty model},$$

not a modification of the Graph Law into a stochastic substrate.

# Part VII
# Positioning, falsifiers, and close

## 18 Positioning and prior art

The individual ingredients of Graphic Equalisation have substantial prior art. The proposed contribution is their conjunction at one minimal substrate level and the additional distinctions forced by making that conjunction executable.

**Graph rewriting and typed transformation.** Algebraic graph transformation provides mature formalisms for typed graphs, rule application, partiality, and structural consistency (Ehrig et al., 2006). Graphic Equalisation adopts graph transformation as substrate vocabulary but makes frame-relative boundary forcing, collapse, and identity part of the same dynamical account.

**Reflection and self-modification.** Computational reflection establishes that a system can represent and modify meta-level structure governing its own execution (Smith, 1982; Maes, 1987). The specific identity "the grammar acting on itself is the loop" is the present paper's claim, not a result attributed to those sources.

**Cybernetics and feedback.** Classical cybernetics and control theory distinguish open-loop dynamics from systems in which error is returned into subsequent control (Wiener, 1948; Ashby, 1956). The residual construction generalises the same causal distinction: mismatch changes later action only where it survives as represented state.

**Quantum measurement and relational description.** The separation of pre-realisation state from realised measurement record is standard in the measurement problem (von Neumann, 1955). Everett's relative-state formulation and Rovelli's relational quantum mechanics provide important precedents for refusing a single privileged observer-independent account of all facts (Everett, 1957; Rovelli, 1996). Graphic Equalisation uses these as neighbouring structures rather than deriving itself from any one interpretation.

**Deterministic quantum theories.** Bohm's 1952 model is a direct proof of principle that deterministic dynamics can reproduce nonrelativistic quantum predictions when supplemented by additional state (Bohm, 1952). Bell and Kochen–Specker impose decisive constraints on local

and noncontextual hidden-variable theories (Section 17). Consequently, the determinism claim in Proposition 17.1 should be read as a commitment requiring an adequate nonlocal/contextual grounding where quantum phenomena demand it, not as a revival of unconstrained classical hidden variables.

**Causal order.** Causal-set theory supplies a well-developed example in which causal order is taken as primitive while continuum metric structure is additional or emergent (Bombelli et al., 1987). Graphic Equalisation makes only the weaker substrate claim that ordinal causal order does not itself entail a real-valued metric time.

**Emergent and relational time.** That time is not a substrate dimension (Section 13) has substantial physics precedent, and the present account sits at the most-local end of it. The Wheeler–DeWitt equation of canonical quantum gravity carries no time parameter (DeWitt, 1967) — the "problem of time" this substrate dissolves rather than solves, there having been no time variable to recover. The Page–Wootters mechanism derives apparent evolution from entanglement between a clock subsystem and the rest (Page and Wootters, 1983), closely matching "time inferred from the relations a frame holds," but retains a single global state where this account is per-frame. Barbour's Machian relationalism takes time to be abstracted from change rather than a container (Barbour, 1999), and Rovelli's relational and thermal-time programme refuses a privileged global time (Rovelli, 1996, 2011). The distinguishing move here is to keep none of the global objects these programmes retain — global wavefunction, global configuration space, global state — reading time entirely from local change.

**Computational-universe and graph-rewrite models.** The closest extant framework is the Wolfram Physics Project, in which the universe is a hypergraph evolved by rewrite rules, time is progressive rule application, and observer-independent structure follows from *causal invariance* — different update orderings yielding the same causal graph (Wolfram, 2002, 2020a,b). The structural agreement is deep: graph plus rewrite rules, time emergent from rule application rather than posited, order-independence, and observer-relative slicing. Four differences locate the present contribution. First, $\Gamma$ is an admissibility grammar that is itself graph data and self-modifying (the grammar-is-the-loop theorem), whereas Wolfram fixes a rule per universe or takes the entire rule space — the Ruliad — at once. Second, collapse realises *one* frame-relative continuation, whereas Wolfram retains all branches (the multiway graph) and derives quantum structure from them. Third, residual and growth-by-minting from it have no counterpart in a fixed rule. Fourth, the present substrate keeps no global object — no single hypergraph being updated — being local and frame-relative throughout, and its claims are information-level and cross-domain rather than an attempt to derive our specific universe. This last is why $c$ falls out here as a *per-frame* unit (developed in the companion physics-grounding paper): sub-rules with closure give each frame its own cycle and hence its own $c = 1$, invariant by construction, whereas a single global update yields $c$ only as an emergent speed limit shown observer-independent by causal invariance — the constant, but not the per-frame machinery beneath it. That an independent programme reached the shared shape from cellular automata and physics, while this one reached it from cognition and engineering, bears on the arrangement claim of Section 1 rather than against its novelty, at the calibrated strength given there.

**Information as constitutive.** That what exists comes to information is Wheeler's *it from bit* (Wheeler, 1990), asserted there at total scope within physics — every particle, every field of force, spacetime itself — and before it Bateson's unit of information, *"a difference which makes a difference"* (Bateson, 1972). Two differences locate what is added, and the first is a deflation rather than an extension. *The ground.* Wheeler derives existence from apparatus-elicited answers to yes-or-no questions, which is why the participatory observer is the most contested part of

that programme; the ground here is relation (*Is*, Proposition 1.1), and a relation requires no apparatus — a rock stands in relations without measuring anything, and the companion is explicit that what merely is cannot observe at all. The same claim is reached on a weaker ground, and without the participatory commitment usually taken to come with it. *The scope.* Wheeler's claim is total within physics; Axiom −1 states it for every frame's every claim, physical or not. That also makes explicit what Bateson left implicit, since *makes a difference* already asks *to whom* and does not say. *The polarity.* The third difference is the smallest to state and cuts deepest. Wheeler's bit is an *answer* — elicited by an apparatus, to a yes-or-no question, and therefore polarised, since what makes one outcome the *yes* is the question that was asked. Nothing here supplies a question, and an edge is not an answer to one. What a relation carries is a distinction, and a distinction has no polarity of its own: Shannon's measure is invariant under any relabelling of the alphabet that preserves the distinctions, so the labels carry none of the information they are attached to (Shannon, 1948). *The bit is unlabelled, and the labels are put there by a frame.* That is not a new principle but Remark 3.2's stated once more — individuation is performed by the container and not by the thing, and a label is a boundary drawn — and it is not a claim that labels are idle. A frame that acts differently on the two sides is doing work with them and paying for them, and they are well-formed for it in the sense of Definition 7.7. What is not substrate is any of it above the bare difference — that two relations differ is forced, and Remark 3.11 gives the argument, while sorting them into kinds, naming the kinds and fixing which side is the *yes* are supplied in that order and none of them given. The price is the one Axiom −1 charges already: no bit is *of* anything absolutely, and what a bit is of cannot be said without naming the frame that says it.

**Information and minimum description.** The preference for the smallest sufficient ontology is the method's rather than this paper's, and is set out with its prior art in the companion *Is*. What matters here is only its consequence for one hypothesis: it motivates the Discrete Sufficiency Hypothesis and does not prove it.

**Standing beside, not replacing.** Graphic Equalisation is not proposed as a replacement for established theories. It is intended to sit beneath or beside them as a substrate description. A grounding may add continuous geometry, conservation laws, quantum amplitudes, relativistic metrics, biological mechanisms, institutional rules, or probabilistic models of unresolved lower-frame observations. In particular, relational quantum mechanics (Rovelli, 1996), Everettian relative-state quantum mechanics (Everett, 1957), and deterministic Bohmian mechanics (Bohm, 1952) make mutually different commitments while remaining compatible with large parts of standard quantum phenomenology; this paper does not require choosing among those complete physical models at the substrate-definition stage. Such additions do not alter Proposition 17.1: within the Graph Law, realised transition remains deterministic once the causally complete antecedent configuration is specified.

The substrate claim remains

| represented state → admissible possibility → collapse → realised state. |
|---|

## 19 Falsifiability commitments

The question of what assessment an account of this kind admits — what a universal claim can risk, why usefulness rather than falsification is what it earns, and what the implementation record shows — is treated in the companion on assessment. This section states the position it reaches and then the commitments themselves.

**The position, in brief.** The discussion above reached its form by successive correction and records those corrections, which is useful for anyone checking the reasoning and useless for anyone who only wants to know where it ended. Stated once, without the history: the purely framework-level part of this account carries no falsifiable content, because a contingent commitment doing no framework-work is idle structure by its own definition of well-formedness. The rest is contentful and answerable, and a counterexample to it *bounds* the account — locates the edge of its range — rather than refuting it from nowhere, which is what residual does everywhere else here. What separates such an account from a mere vocabulary is that a counterexample is conceivable at all. Establishing it would require enumerating an unbounded frontier and cannot terminate; bounding it requires one extant thing that does not fit. And what it earns beyond that is not truth but use: whether it does work its absence would not, which is a record and not a proof, and is reported above with its gaps.

Each commitment below is marked [SHAPE] or [DETAIL]. A [DETAIL] failing is a revision: the account survives with that mechanism replaced. A [SHAPE] failing costs *range* rather than a mechanism, because what fails is something the substrate is claimed to require or to permit — so the account does not hold where it claimed to, which is the more serious of the two and is still a boundary rather than an annihilation, per the discussion above. The distinction is the one Section 1 rests its epistemic claim on, and marking it here is what makes that claim checkable rather than asserted.

One caution about the framework-level statement above, since stated bare it invites the wrong reading and the companion reaches the same place from the other side. *Carries no falsifiable content* and the companion's *falsifiable, but not coherently so* are not two verdicts to choose between. Both sentences are attempts to say something a reader's ordinary falsifiability frame has no slot for, that frame taking a counterexample to be a coherent state of affairs one then looks for. Where the putative counterexample would not cohere, neither *testable* nor *empty* applies as the reader hears it, and the distinction that separates the two cases sits below the grain at which falsifiability is usually argued. So the papers do not disagree, and either sentence read alone will look as though they do.

**[shape] Composition.** Prior to the component commitments below: the arrangement claim of Section 1 fails if the structure's recurrence across unrelated domains is an artefact of description rather than a property of those domains. Evidence against it would be a demonstration that any sufficiently rich domain can be rendered in this vocabulary with equal facility, including domains chosen adversarially to lack the structure. Evidence bearing on it is independent re-derivation, in a domain's own idiom, without reference to this theory — which rules out this vocabulary having supplied the structure, and does not by itself distinguish the composition claim from the shared-constraint reading the account predicts anyway. The burden here is deliberately on the negative side, because that side is closeable: a single adversarial domain rendered with equal facility settles it against the claim. No requirement is placed on the positive side to exhibit domains that share *nothing* — every pair of domains shares something, so that standard is unmeetable in principle, and discharging it would mean enumerating domains until an assessor chose to stop. A test whose stopping condition lies with the assessor rather than with the claim is not a test, and this paper does not offer one.

1. [DETAIL] **Solutions are nearly unique under a binding constraint.** The posit under Propositions 16.1 and 16.2. Fails if structures optimising hard against the same binding constraint, over the same region, are exhibited arriving at arrangements that do not resemble each other — in which case constraint narrows the space without selecting within it, and both propositions weaken to that.

2. [DETAIL] **Located degradation.** Fails if, for classifications whose purpose is specifiable in advance of inspecting their failures, failure cases are distributed no differently near the

purpose boundary than across the rest of the domain (Hypothesis 16.4).

3. [SHAPE] **Convergence is not enforced.** Fails if convergence between independently developed classifications of one domain extends to the cases where the classifications' purposes differ, which is what a privileged boundary would produce and cost-shaped convergence would not (Proposition 16.1). Marked [SHAPE] on reconsideration: a privileged boundary is not a mechanism this account could replace, since the contingency of the rules that draw a boundary is what Section 16 rests on and what Axiom -1 asserts one level up. Exhibiting one costs range rather than a mechanism.

4. [SHAPE] **Minimal graph sufficiency.** Fails if basic realised graph dynamics require a primitive beyond $(g, r, \Gamma)$ rather than represented or relational structure.

5. [SHAPE] **Discrete sufficiency.** Fails if a claimed observable consequence cannot be preserved by any discrete representation, including dynamically varying quantisation, but is preserved by a genuinely non-discrete primitive.

6. [SHAPE] **Antecedent-state principle.** Fails if a realised transition can require as antecedent a fact that exists only as consequence of that same transition, absent prior fixed-point structure.

7. [SHAPE] **Graph-law determinism.** Fails if two genuinely identical, causally complete antecedent configurations produce different realised successors without any additional causally operative distinction. Variation observed only from a frame that omits determining dimensions does not constitute such a falsification.

8. [SHAPE] **No implicit historical state.** Fails if an unrepresented past event alters later transition structure despite leaving no causal trace in graph or boundary state.

9. [SHAPE] **Frame-relative identity.** Fails if sameness and persistence are derivable from $(g, r, \Gamma)$ alone without individuation.

10. [SHAPE] **Residual is inadmissibility.** Fails if a graph-originated deformation can be left as residual by a containing frame that nonetheless admits it under $\Gamma_{W_c}$, or absorbed while inadmissible, so that residual and non-admission come apart.

11. [SHAPE] **Cost is the write.** Fails if a substrate operation other than writing a delta carries an irreducible cost — if reading, holding a standing structure, or the boundary relation itself must be paid for with a cost that is not the cost of the write they occasion. [SHAPE] because persistence would not be free if it failed, taking the carvings section, the crossings section and Remark 7.5 together rather than singly; the argument is there.

12. [SHAPE] **Self-change is subset-change.** The claim is that a graph changes itself and its subgraphs directly (rule-governed), and affects its container only as a subset of it, by propagation through coupling. Fails if a graph changes its container by a means other than changing the region of it that the graph is — a container-change not propagating from the graph's own subset — or if a graph can self-terminate without acting on the container.

13. [SHAPE] **Minting is a rule.** Fails if grammar-extension (growth) requires a primitive operation beneath the rules rather than a reflective rule subject to the same economics, admissibility, and antecedent-state principle — in particular, if a graph can mint its first distinctions without any seeded from its container.

14. [SHAPE] **Partial-order sufficiency.** Fails if realised dynamics require a total order over collapses in distinct frames — a global simultaneity — rather than only the boundary-induced partial order.

15. [SHAPE] **Globally-async/locally-sync.** Fails if coupling never induces local synchrony (boundary-related collapses remain unordered) or if synchrony is forced without coupling (a global instant exists independent of any boundary).

16. [SHAPE] **Decoherence is one operation.** Fails if the manner in which an inadmissible write fails is a property of what was attempted rather than of the frame's rules — that is, if one frame under one rule set yields structurally distinct failure modes for two inadmissible writes, with the difference not attributable to that frame's own policy (Remark 9.1). Different outcomes across *different* frames do not bear on this; that is what the claim predicts.

17. [SHAPE] **A swallowed failure is relocated, never closed.** Fails if a frame can *settle* from inside that a swallowed failure went nowhere, rather than relocating the question to what it cannot inspect. Not that a frame cannot detect its own handler discarding a failure — it can; the exposure is the settling. One of the four places named below at which the same event would be found.

18. [SHAPE] **Dependents are not held by the referent.** Fails if realised graph dynamics require a structure to carry the set of things depending on it — back-references primitive rather than installed — so that the consequences of removing a structure are recoverable from that structure alone, without querying the frames holding the references and without paid machinery (Remark 9.5). A substrate in which deletion is always clean falsifies this, and would also remove the distinction between an absence and a vacancy.

19. [SHAPE] **A boundary is known only by crossing it.** Fails if a frame can *settle* the location of its own admissibility boundary without any write that crosses it. Extrapolation from inside the admissible region evidences a boundary and is not at issue; establishing one would be (Remark 9.4). This is the epistemic member of the same family as the provenance commitment below, and fails in the same manner — by a procedure that closes the question rather than relocating it.

20. [DETAIL] **Robustness trades against legibility.** Fails if a policy can bound a frame's residuals without reducing what its failures disclose about its grammar — a handler that both absorbs and reports with no loss (Remark 9.4). Cheaply testable in software, and marked [DETAIL] because the account survives its loss with the trade weakened to a tendency.

21. [SHAPE] **Capability and accessibility are distinct.** Fails if what a frame's gates admit and what it can reach from where it stands collapse into one quantity — if there is no case of a frame able to represent and perform an arrangement it cannot reach, or none of a frame able to reach what it cannot represent (Section 10). The coupling claimed between them, that a capacity shortfall narrows aperture and so degrades capability over time, fails separately if aperture width is unaffected by demands on capacity.

22. [DETAIL] **A hazard is a signed capability change above a frame-relative threshold.** Fails if a disclosure can be a hazard to a frame in which the negative sign is not admissible, or if the magnitude at which one counts is fixed independently of the frame bearing it rather than as a ratio to what that frame can absorb. Fails also if the threshold sits somewhere other than where the impact forces a write.

23. [DETAIL] **Externalising lengthens the interval before a crossing is legible.** Fails if the time for a crossing's cost to become signable is independent of whether the frame bearing it can report — that is, if costs placed on frames that cannot signal return no more slowly than costs placed on frames that can (Section 10).

24. [SHAPE] **No free lunch.** Fails on a realised change whose cost is absent in the frame that made it *and* in the container that sustains it, on inspection of both — a payment traced

to neither rather than merely not yet looked for. The burden is finite and on the negative side: asking instead for a cost absent at *every* frame would demand an enumeration this account says cannot terminate, and for which Axiom -1 supplies no standpoint. The claim is empirical, not modal. A costless change is admissible; none has been traced. Note that a frame experiencing freeness is not the counterexample and never was — at the table the next plate genuinely costs the diner nothing, and the buffet pays — so the test is whether the payment appears anywhere it is looked for, not whether some frame gets something for nothing.

25. [SHAPE] **Termination follows supply, not containment.** Fails if containment alone determines it — if a subgraph must stop when the graph containing it stops, even where its primitives are supplied from beyond that graph (Remark 9.3). The partial case carries its own clause: fails if a frame losing part of its supply must either stop or continue correctly, rather than running with an incomplete operation set and undefined behaviour, or if such a frame can enumerate what it has lost from inside — which would also falsify the provenance commitment below.

26. [SHAPE] **The relativity of grounding is a consequence, and can fail as one.** Fails if a view can be informative without standing in relation to what it views, or if relation is not what carries information here. A consequence has content and can fail, which a posit or a costless guard could not (Remark 2.1). The second disjunct is the companion's own identification of distinction with relation, so this is where the account is thinnest rather than where it is safest, and it is marked [SHAPE] because what fails with it is the range of everything derived through it.

27. [DETAIL] **Description length is constitutive, not merely a method.** Fails if a relation carrying no content *given the others* nevertheless adds to what a thing is — the conditional form of Remark 3.9's result, which Remark 2.3 uses and does not prove. Marked [DETAIL] because the account survives its failure: minimum description length reverts to the imported method the companion already had, and only the claim that the two are one principle at two grips is lost.

28. [SHAPE] **Provenance is never closed by inference.** Fails if a frame can *settle* the provenance of its own operator set from inside: if some in-frame procedure establishes, rather than merely evidences, whether its operators are self-supplied, how many distinct structures supply them, or whether a serial hidden supply underlies an apparently asynchronous frame. Not that primitives fail to leak — they do, and Proposition 14.2 says so. This is the single prohibition of Section 15 in operational form, argued there.

Two commitments that once sat in the list above are consequences rather than wagers, and are stated here instead of counted there — the standard is the one the composition paragraph sets, that a test whose stopping condition lies with the assessor is not a test. *Admissibility is not armour* and *higher-frame first-class structure* are closer to consequences of the definitions than to empirical risks: given a container that may force arbitrarily, self-admissibility not constraining it follows, and given that a frame's state about another frame is ordinary state, its independence from that other frame's primitives follows. They are retained because they are load-bearing and a reader should see what they commit to, and they are marked here as derivations rather than wagers.

*Minimal graph sufficiency* is not a third such case, though it can look like one: it might be said to absorb its own falsifier, on the grounds that any proposed fourth primitive can be redescribed as represented or relational structure. But that redescription is not a rescue — *it is what the claim says.* The commitment is one of *sufficiency*: not that nothing else exists, but that nothing else is required. A named feature turning out to be graph data confirms it rather

than evading it, and the paper's own results are that pattern rather than exceptions to it, since frame, dimension, time and cost each entered as a candidate primitive and left as represented structure.

So the falsifier is closeable and the burden sits on the positive side, where it is constructive: exhibit realised dynamics that *cannot run* on $(g, r, \Gamma)$. Proposing a primitive is not the test and never was. And the place to conduct it is the minimum rather than the maximum — the rock of Remark 3.3, where $r$ and $\Gamma$ are absent at the grain of individuation and there is accordingly nothing extra present to smuggle the work into. A sufficiency claim is tested where least is available, not where most is.

Two commitments below expose the two postulates the ledger counts — the realisation operator, and the destroy/preserve distinction, whose falsifier is the no-copy entry since what it tests is whether the discarding class is the general one, which is more serious than a mis-tag: an unexposed commitment is not merely graded wrongly. Both were folded away in one pass and restored by the next audit (Remark 2.6), and both keep their falsifiers throughout, because whether a claim is postulated or derived moves where a failure would propagate from and not whether it can happen.

29. [SHAPE] **Realisation is single-valued.** Fails if realised dynamics are better accounted for by retaining the admissible set than by selecting one member of it — and the qualification is the whole test: a treatment carrying all continuations forward must recover the observed statistics from the retained structure *without adding a measure over it to do so*, since retention that needs a weighting has reintroduced selection under another name.

30. [SHAPE] **No-copy** (the destroy/preserve postulate's exposure)**.** Fails if a substrate change can preserve its predecessor without paying to keep it — if retention is available at no cost rather than as a purchased record. What is at stake is the Landauer reading of Section 7, which requires change and irreversible operation to coincide. The arrow of the event order is *not* at stake and earlier versions of this entry said it was: direction is carried by the asymmetry of enablement, which stands whether or not a change preserves what it followed.

Four of the entries above are one risk counted four times, and the list says so rather than banking the arithmetic. *Provenance is never closed by inference*, *A boundary is known only by crossing it*, *A swallowed failure is relocated, never closed* and the second clause of *Termination follows supply* are each falsified by the same event: an in-frame procedure that *settles* a question rather than relocating it. Two of the four already acknowledge an overlap in their own text and all four were still counted separately, three of them [SHAPE] — so an account whose headline is that a [SHAPE] failure costs range was reporting one exposure as four. They are kept as separate entries because they name genuinely different places to look for the event, which is what a falsifier is for; what is withdrawn is the implication that failing them would cost four separate things. Failing any one of them is the single prohibition of Section 15 failing, and that is one result, not four.

Two notes on the list as a whole. Nothing is claimed to be closeable cheaply — *discrete sufficiency* requires ruling out every discrete representation including dynamically varying ones, which is hard rather than ill-formed, and the distinction between the two is the point of this paragraph. And the marks themselves are revisable: three entries above were re-marked after the commitments for Section 8's newer material were written, because setting out a new commitment made the criterion sharper than it had been when the older ones were assigned.

## 20 Conclusion

The theory is deliberately small. A graph need not know what it is, where it is, what will happen, or what it wants. Present structure determines admissible continuation; interaction and

collapse produce realised history; realised history changes the antecedent from which subsequent possibility is generated.

Recursion requires no external homunculus. Where the grammar acts on its own represented structure, the grammar is the loop. World forcing is not self-action, residual is discrepancy rather than diagnosis, history matters only where it survives as present structure, and identity exists only under individuation by a frame.

Pressed for what is compulsory, the theory keeps almost nothing. What survives every attempted removal is structure with relations among its parts; what rules running adds is that anything *happens* (Remark 3.2), which is the condition of everything this account is about and is not the condition of there being anything; the specific laws above it — inertia, closure, the shape of collapse, and the write-economics itself — are contingent rule content rather than necessities, and not strict universals (Remark 7.12), which is the sense in which this substrate underlies groundings without dictating them.

Every mechanism used here belongs to someone else and is cited as such; the claim is the arrangement (Section 1), and the method by which the arrangement was reached is removal rather than addition — of primitive time, of a privileged frame, of a cost that is the same whatever runs the rules. Removals are small to state and large in consequence, because results that had been independently working around a deleted assumption stop being independent.

The account forbids one thing, and Section 15 states it and its formal analogue: a frame cannot get outside itself. Everything else that has looked impossible has so far turned out to be contingent rule content that some grounding happens not to instantiate — which is a measure of how much had been filed as necessary without being checked, and is not itself evidence for the account, since the enumeration is open and this paper does not offer an open enumeration as a test (Section 19).

The regress in that prohibition has both ends, and neither is safe to state alone. A superframe dissolves the frame below's limit: holding both of two locations it has units closing across them, and quantities the subframes could not obtain are ordinary in its terms. And a superframe is a frame, so it reproduces the same blindness about its own running. Ascent buys something real and never buys everything — the limit is dissolved locally at every step and terminated at none, which is why no amount of it yields a view from nowhere. What ascent yields is a different somewhere.

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